STATE OF THE FUTURE

Policy Camp

Policy Camp 2026

A summary of the day

Gavin Freeguard
October 2026



ABOUT THIS REPORT

On 23 July 2026, around 250 people – policymakers and others from the public sector and beyond – came together at University College London for the first-ever Policy Camp, all about how to improve policymaking.

This was an unconference: those who turned up decided the agenda, pitching and voting on session ideas.

This report brings together notes from the unconference sessions, transcripts of the keynote Q&A at the start of the day and presentation at the end, and attendees' reflections on the day.

policycamp.org.uk

WHY STATE OF THE FUTURE IS WORKING ON THIS

Public servants need spaces where they can come together, with others, to talk about what matters to them, share lessons (and frustrations), and build connections. Unconferences have been a useful format for that – for example, in data and digital professions – but have not previously been organised by and for policymakers to discuss the future of their profession. Policy Camp is an important space enabling that.

The day itself was inspiring, but the subjects highlighted and discussed have a wider audience among policy professionals and beyond. This report aims to share them beyond the day.

State of the Future was one of many partners in Policy Camp. A full list is on page 5.

sotf.org.uk

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Gavin Freeguard is founding director of State of the Future. He is one of the founders and organisers of Policy Camp, and is a co-founder and organiser of TransformGov Talks (where the idea of Policy Camp emerged from).

Everything in the report is taken from contributions on the day itself: the morning Q&A and afternoon presentation, notes taken during unconference sessions, and reflections shared via a 'giveaway and takeaway' exercise at the end of the day and feedback form after the event. Thank you to everyone who came and contributed. Any errors are the author's own. Views expressed by the keynote speakers are their own.

This report is published under a CC-BY licence and should be credited to State of the Future. Photographs should be credited to Ned Gartside/Policy Camp.

CONTENTS

CONTENTS	3
INTRODUCTION	4
SPONSORS AND PARTNERS	5
KEYNOTE: JONATHAN SLATER IN CONVERSATION WITH SUZANNAH BRECKNELL	6
SESSION SUMMARIES	13
PRESENTATION: TEST, LEARN AND GROW	26
REFLECTIONS ON THE DAY	39
WHAT HAPPENS NEXT	43
ANNEX: FULL GIVEAWAYS, TAKEAWAYS AND OTHER FEEDBACK	44
THANKS	56



INTRODUCTION

ABOUT POLICY CAMP

On Thursday 23 July 2026, around 250 people gathered at University College London for the first-ever Policy Camp.

This brought together public servants working on policy in central and local government and the wider public sector, public servants working in other disciplines, academics, think tankers, practitioners from the private sector and others to discuss how we can improve how policy is developed and delivered.

Policy Camp was an 'unconference': those who turned up designed the agenda, together. There were four timeslots during the day where several different rooms were available for discussion (38 slots in all). At the start of the day, we invited people to pitch ideas for sessions – these were added to large noticeboards (along with some ideas submitted in advance) and grouped together. Attendees then used sticky dots to vote on the sessions they would like to attend, to help us allocate rooms depending on the level of interest. Discussions took place under the Chatham House Rule – information can be shared (as it is in this report) but not in a way that can be used to identify any participants.

While we sorted the agenda, there was a keynote Q&A session, with **Jonathan Slater** (former head of the Policy Profession) in conversation with **Suzannah Brecknell** (co-editor-in-chief, Civil Service World). The four unconference timeslots then took up most of the day. We finished with a presentation from the Cabinet Office's **Test, Learn and Grow** team (**Nigel Keohane**, head of strategy; **Jess Hunt,** head of product), before a final wrap-up inviting attendees to give us feedback on the event and the key insights and actions they were taking away with them.

Policy Camp was organised by volunteers inside and outside government (these are listed at the end of this report) and made possible by the kind support of several sponsors (listed on the next page). The idea emerged from a conversation after a TransformGov Talks event in June 2025.

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report follows the pattern of the day. It starts with a transcript of the morning keynote with Jonathan and Suzannah. It then includes a short summary of all the unconference sessions where notes were taken. A transcript (with slides) of the Test, Learn and Grow presentation follows that. It concludes with a summary of reflections on the day – the 'giveaway and takeaway' session we ran at the end – before a brief summary of what happens next.

An annex includes more detail on people's reflections: all of the things they took away with them and all of the feedback we received about the day itself.

SPONSORS AND PARTNERS

HOST SPONSOR AND PLATINUM SPONSOR

PLATINUM SPONSORS

GOLD SPONSORS

SILVER SPONSORS

ORGANISING PARTNERS

MEDIA PARTNER

HOST University College London | PLATINUM Projects by IF + Register Dynamics + Transform + TPXimpact

GOLD Design Council + Oxford Insights | SILVER Delib + UKGovCamp + Unboxed

ORGANISING PARTNERS Ceva + Holistic Agility + State of the Future + TPXimpact + TransformGov Talks

MEDIA PARTNER Civil Service World

KEYNOTE: JONATHAN SLATER IN CONVERSATION WITH SUZANNAH BRECKNELL

The day began with an introduction to Policy Camp and the unconference format, before we invited people to pitch session ideas. While we turned those pitches into the agenda for the day – the 'session grid' – we had a keynote.

Jonathan Slater, former permanent secretary at the Department for Education and head of the Policy Profession and now a visiting professor at King's College London and Queen Mary University of London, was interviewed by **Suzannah Brecknell**, one of the editors-in-chief of Civil Service World. Jonathan has previously written a report on 'Fixing Whitehall's broken policy machine', and also spoke about civil service reform at TransformGov Talks in April 2026.

This is a lightly edited transcript of the session.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

Suzannah Brecknell: Thanks, Gavin [Freeguard, who ran the introduction and pitching], for pointing out that we've got Emran Mian on the cover [this month - just as the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, where he was permanent secretary, was abolished]. We are glass half full at Civil Service World, so we like to think of it – rather than being already out of date, it's now a collector's item, memorializing a moment in time. And our previous cover star was made Cabinet Secretary 10 days after we interviewed her. So you know, it's not a sign of bad luck to be on the cover of Civil Service World...

One of the pre-pitches that was put in was around moving beyond the persona of policy maker. So can you first of all give us a little bit about your career, your background and tell us what persona did you feel you had? Did you think of yourself throughout your career as a policymaker, coming in from wherever you were to tell people what to do, or if not, what was the persona that you adopted?

Jonathan Slater: Delighted to be here. So I worked with British Rail, a couple of years as an operational researcher, then Newham then Islington Council, and then by chance I became a civil servant in 2001, with Tony Blair, back in the days when he was really popular, before Iraq. And although I had had the word 'policy' in my job title at Islington council, it wasn't really a word we used a lot, with any precision or even at all, about what we were doing. And then I found myself in the civil service and goodness me, the word 'policy' was used more than any other; people banged on about it all the time and I really wasn't at all sure what it was. And I spent 15 years trying to understand what it was and I came to the view, in the end, that what 'policy' means in the civil service is talking to ministers – that's what it means.

You have multi-disciplinary teams these days. People whose jobs are to understand digital, law, project management, implementation, and there's a policy maker. What does the policy maker do? The policy maker is the convenor of the team. They listen to what all the experts say and then go off and have a conversation with the ministers and then come back and tell them. That's been my experience, and it did often seem to me in my career that it would be really quite interesting if you just cut out the middleman.

My first policy job was in the Ministry of Justice and the key task was to see what we could do to reduce reoffending. And there are a lot of probation officers and prison officers who spent a whole career, a whole lifetime, working with offenders trying to help them get back on the straight and narrow. And then there was a large group of policy makers who hadn't spent very much time at all with prisoners or people on probation, because they're moving from job to job and they were good at talking to ministers. And so it was the latter group who was tasked to come up with the plan reducing reoffending, rather than the former. And when I would say, 'well, why? Why don't we just ask the people who run the prisons to come up with that?', you get stuff about provider capture, that they will lack innovation, they'll be stuck in the old ways. I don't mean there isn't any role at all for people who are good at understanding politics and understanding ministers and turning a sort of technical conversation into a conversation with politicians, but it really isn't the most significant thing I ever did.

Suzannah: I'm hearing something there about the, kind of, handing over of power and relationships, and access to people who are likely to be experts, which ties in, I think, to something we spoke about earlier and which is the big theme mentioned again over there [on the session pitching boards], discussed a lot in the news: devolution. We're moving into this new era, we have a new prime minister who is saying devolution, devolution, devolution. ('Education, education, education.') So you've had a career across different sectors, across different policy areas – can you give us a bit of a reflection on that expertise, that experience – when have you seen devolution work well and not work well?

Jonathan: Thank you. Again, it's sort of inevitable that if you come from local government into central government, certainly my experience is that you're sort of fed up with people above you telling you what to do. You want a bit more freedom to do it yourself. And so most of my 20 years as a civil servant was encouraging my colleagues to use less power than they had, and hand it over. And I'd say that wasn't because I was so uniquely insightful; it was just because of my background.

I guess that if I had come straight out of, let's say, a prestigious international university, straight into the civil service to be told I was joining the best civil service in the world, then I would have a very high opinion of the organization I'd have joined, and myself, and my role within it, and the last thing I would want to do is to hand over that power to other people. In fact, when you talk to any civil servant who's just arrived, 'why have you joined the civil service?', you know (whether they tell you the truth or not) they tend to say, 'to make a difference', by which they mean they want to get their hands dirty, sort something out. And the same pressure, of course, is on politicians.

You know it does strike me that in the speech where the new prime minister announced, 'it's all about devolution', in the same speech before he actually went into 10 Downing Street, he announced a national target that's got to be achieved across the whole of the country: the end of rough sleeping. I'm not saying that's a bad thing at all. I'm not saying that you shouldn't have a national objective of that sort. I'm not even saying that it's wrong to fund that objective by taking money – that was otherwise going to be spent empowering local areas to meet local priorities – and suck that into the centre and spend it on a national objective. I'm not suggesting for a moment that's wrong. What I am saying is it's obviously the opposite of devolution, and you can sort of see why the new prime minister would make that sort of statement. He's seeking to reconnect with the public and demonstrate the government is on their side. You know that is obviously a good thing to do but the pressure to suck it up and decide from the centre is incredibly powerful and so the opposite happens.

Devolution happens when you're lucky enough to be working for people who don't think that they're cleverer than anybody else. Who don't think that they've got the answers. And it happens if you don't think you've got the answers, too. If you think you've got the answers (and you might even be right), you think, let's just force them through. Yeah. Don't mess about. Don't devolve. If you've got the answers, you shouldn't play games. Devolve if you think that somebody else will come up with a better solution than you. And you've got to really believe it. And you're, as I say, more likely to believe that if you've worked elsewhere first, than if you've just always been a civil servant.

The best example I had in my own career was (again) on reducing reoffending. I was working for two extremely experienced ministers: first of all, Jack Straw, and then Ken Clarke, over an election, and

they both recognized that they didn't have all the answers when it came to reducing reoffending. I was asked to come up with a plan and essentially the plan was to give some ex-offenders the task of reducing reoffending by people coming out of prison. It seemed to me that the people who would be most expert in the question about what would make ex-offenders stop reoffending were ex-offenders. And we designed a deal in which we allocated funding to them to achieve that objective in whatever way (so long as it was 'legal') they could do it. And it was wonderful because I was working with two politicians who said, 'yeah, let's give it a go', and we gave it a go, and we compared the reoffending rates of the prison we chose for the deal with other similar prisons elsewhere. It was done by independent analysis and you know I wouldn't be telling you the story if I wasn't able to give you the punch line that, yes, the reoffending rate fell more in Peterborough than elsewhere because of what they knew, and what we couldn't possibly know. That was a wonderful real-life experience of what happens if you trust people who know more about the subject than you do.

Suzannah: You've answered my last question, which is around how can you inspire us that change is possible – you've given us an example and I think the challenge there around, actually the role of the policy maker is almost to disappear, to say 'okay, I'm here to convene, I'm here to let other people have good ideas'. Sometimes the role is to say, 'we know how we're going to make it happen' but often, it's about being a facilitator, how you make a difference through other people, which is quite a culturally challenging or individually challenging thing for a professional to do. We've got ten minutes, so before I open up to questions, do you want to add anything on that question, that reflection, about: actually is the role of a policymaker to disappear?



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

Jonathan: I certainly think there should be a lot fewer than there currently are. You know, as I say, there are some things which you're going to run nationally. Defence is a good example of that, where you're not going to have a different approach to defending the nation if you're in Cornwall versus Scarborough. But for something that I know quite a lot about, education, definitely the way to help children succeed in Cornwall is really very different from the way they are going to succeed in Scarborough.

I can remember when I was at the Department of Education looking into why children were struggling to learn to read in schools in a particular part of the north west and we couldn't get our heads around it at all. But the team locally understood eventually that the key problem was that too many of the children in the classroom couldn't see the board because they hadn't got their eyesight tested because their parents couldn't afford the glasses. And that's the sort of thing you're unlikely as a national policy maker to design.

And so, at induction meetings when you started at the Department for Education, I would invite them to think: what would happen if the DfE didn't exist tomorrow? Of course, teachers and social workers would carry on doing their work. Would we be adding more value by our instructions as to what they should achieve? And you know, you need some people at the centre, but you definitely need a lot fewer – both because some services are going to be run nationally as I said and others, you need a framework within which people can learn from each other. Nationally you want some people who can make sure the data is spread, lessons are learned and all the rest of it, but just dial down so much the instructions.

To take a simple example, when I wrote about this in the context of why do schools fail working-class children so much, one of my recommendations last year was that you just do away with Ofsted because Ofsted doesn't know the answer either. And so, if we don't know what is the solution to improving the life chances of working-class children, why would you have an inspectorate making sure people do a particular set of things?

So yes, some, not so many.

Suzannah: I think what's encouraging, obviously, everyone here today does not think they have all the answers or they wouldn't come here to learn from colleagues across government agencies, different sectors. So people here today, any of you have a question for Jonathan?

Audience question 1: Do you think that the physical movement of policy out of Westminster, out of London, out of Number 10 – do you think that is going to create a positive impact on place-based policy making? Do you think the everyday person is going to notice that difference?

Audience question 2: Just generally interested in your reflections on what opportunity the new government presents for us to improve policymaking and what the role of policymakers should be to push for that over the coming weeks.

Jonathan: So the answer to the first question: it could go either way. When I arrived at the Department for Education there were teams of people around the country, in Coventry, in Cambridge, in Sheffield and so on and that meant the quality of the advice received in DfE was

significantly better than in the previous days when it was all based in London, because we got the advantage of people all over the country able to contribute, and so long as they were out engaging with children and other learners in their local communities, then they got the advantage of that. So that has potential.

The happiest staff as measured by the staff survey when I was there were – somewhat disappointing to my ego – people who saw me the least. They were the people who were in Blackpool, in Scarborough, working with local groups of schools called the Opportunity Areas Programme and they loved it because they were really connected with the world rather than, you know in meetings with each other, which unfortunately is what too many of us have to do. So it could be really exciting if the connection is between those civil servants and their communities.

The risk to guard against is that this happens instead of devolution: 'I'll tell you what, rather than empowering the people of Sheffield to come up with the plan for Sheffield, we'll send a group of clever people in Whitehall and get them an office in Sheffield to tell the local people what to do'. Either is possible. Let's choose the first option. And you know, I think, I imagine that's what Andy Burnham and his team wants to do, but they have a lot of forces against them.

And then more generally, what are the opportunities? Well, I don't know the prime minister, but he seems like a guy who really cares. That's what he seems like. He seems like a guy who cares about poverty, about people who've been left behind and he talks, doesn't he, about really wanting to do something about that. And I don't think – because he's been a mayor for the last several years, he's not got – how could he have? – a sort of well-developed plan for how. And of course, we all know the financial challenges to be faced. So what an amazing opportunity for people who are interested in improving the lot of vulnerable people to devise new ways of doing it.

I arrived in 2001, as I said, when money was no object and you could employ as many doctors, nurses, teachers, police officers as you could find and we did deliver. That was easy. If you can recruit as many doctors and nurses as you want, you can reduce waiting times through central control. That's what we did. Not sure that, whether that, was the best thing to do. In the world we're in now, you haven't got that option. You've got to design something really different. And I would have thought with Andy Burnham as the prime minister and Antonia Romeo as an experienced cabinet secretary, they are both in the business of ideas.

My final thought is that that time when I did the most interesting devolution thing I have ever done – handing over ex-offender policy to ex-offenders – was done in 2010 right as the age of austerity was biting and everybody knew that we had to try something really different, and so we did. So now could be a great time to be working in this area.

Audience question 3: It strikes me that the main problem is that we're not speaking to people on the frontline. In my policy area (I'm at the Ministry of Justice) we speak to frontline people every day. The problem I think is that there's no stability. There's so much uncertainty. And I just wondered if you could speak to that. To me it's social media, it's the 24-hour news cycle. It's not that we're not speaking to people that are affected by things that we're doing. It's about change. It's more of a vent because there's no long-term thinking. It's all about the five second clip.

Audience question 4: How do civil society and government best work together to achieve impact?

Audience question 5: I worked on a project in the Ministry of Justice which brought in people with experience of reoffending to work out how to reduce reoffending, and that was in 2021. So I guess my question is about the longevity of policy making, and when we learn a lesson about what works, how can we make sure we learn that lesson for good?



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

Jonathan: All great questions. So civil society and policy makers will work well together, won't they, where there is will and skill and permission on both sides to do so. And it's a fantastically obvious point, isn't it? I think there's some serious stuff going on in Liverpool at the moment – there are lots of examples that you'll no doubt be discussing today, but a great example in Liverpool of some innovative approaches designed to improve the quality of education for young people, driven by the third sector, with the mayor, the local authority seeing their role as facilitative. I think there's a great opportunity for the Department for Education to learn from that and to support initiatives like that to grow.

It can only happen, as I say, where both parties want to play and where politicians are prepared to allow them to do so. And that sometimes doesn't apply. You know, I couldn't give you lots of examples from my career of that sort of success. Maybe I was unlucky. My own experience says be always on the lookout for the opportunity and when you've got it, take it. Be prepared. My permanent secretary at the Ministry of Justice gave me a year to work on the plan before the 2010 election, because we didn't know what was going to happen; we just knew it was going to be different. So that's my answer, the best answer I've got to that question.

Of course you're absolutely right, on the extent to which social media encourages us all to live in our own bubbles and be reinforced by each other, have our views reinforced. It's bad for us and is a big subject in its own right.

The notion, though, of government responding to the latest message and having an announcement rather than sticking in there for the long term to achieve success was not invented as a consequence of Twitter. You're right to say it's what works, but that's always the challenge, isn't it? Even in a world without social media, politicians understandably want to be able to say to the public, 'you elected me, this is what I did' and they want to say 'this is what I did today'. I think that pre-dated social media, albeit (as you say) it has made it worse.

Again, there's no point me inviting you or anybody else to bash their head against a brick wall. Sometimes you're working for a politician who's not interested in the latest headline. And I got that twice roughly at the same time from Jack [Straw] and Ken [Clarke]. And so I made the most of the opportunity. Sometimes you can go for it. Sometimes you can't. There it is. Not a very sophisticated answer, but you deal with the world as you find it. Do the very best you can in the circumstances you find yourself.

[On long-term policymaking] Well, how can you? Well, you can't. Can you? I mean, I remember shortly after I arrived in the Cabinet Office and being put on a panel and being asked by a business person, wouldn't it be great if politicians just stuck to a 10-year plan and implemented it and it didn't change over time? And I said, no, because then we would be living in China and I prefer to be living in the UK. I'd prefer the situation in which the public can say 'that's rubbish', somebody else is going to see if they can do better. And there is a downside in a democracy. I mean, there really is. I've been doing quite a lot of work in Central Asia. They can't believe it, how quickly stuff changes in our country.

And it was only a year after I had done my pilot that Ken Clarke was replaced by Chris Grayling, who was not such a good minister, who was certain that he knew what the right answer was and he imposed it across the whole of the country and it was utter disaster. But that's the price you pay for living in a democracy. It just is. It is what it is. Do the best you can. That's all I've got.

Suzannah: So, prepare yourself – prepare yourself for the opportunities that are there as they come and do the best you can with the world you are in.

SESSION SUMMARIES

Across the day, there were a total of 38 slots available for discussion, with nine rooms available in each of the first and second time slots (1145-1225, 1230-1310), and ten in each of the third and fourth time slots (1410-1450, 1455-1535).

Below we summarise each session where notes were taken. We have grouped them together by subject for ease of reading (we've included the time slot and room where the event took place). In some cases, we've pulled out some practical takeaways, like things to read or useful resources (there's often practical insight in the main text, too).

The original notes from each session, ordered by timeslot and room, can be found on the Policy Camp website. It includes the titles for sessions where notes were not taken:

- Failure patterns in local services – how can policymakers help? (Session 1, G02)
- Build resilience across private sectors (Session 2, G02)
- A new social contract for young people (Session 2, SQG1)
- How can scientific evidence inform policy? (Session 3, Wilkins)
- Data sharing across jurisdictions (Session 3, SR20)
- Protecting equalities in times of political unrest (Session 3, G02)
- Water safety and drowning prevention (Session 3, Committee)
- Circular economy in construction and automotive (Session 4, SR20 – didn't go ahead)
- The green kerb – parking policy for kerbside space (Session 4, G02)
- Prevention theory: Save via the NHS, more to spend in local government? (Session 4, Committee).



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

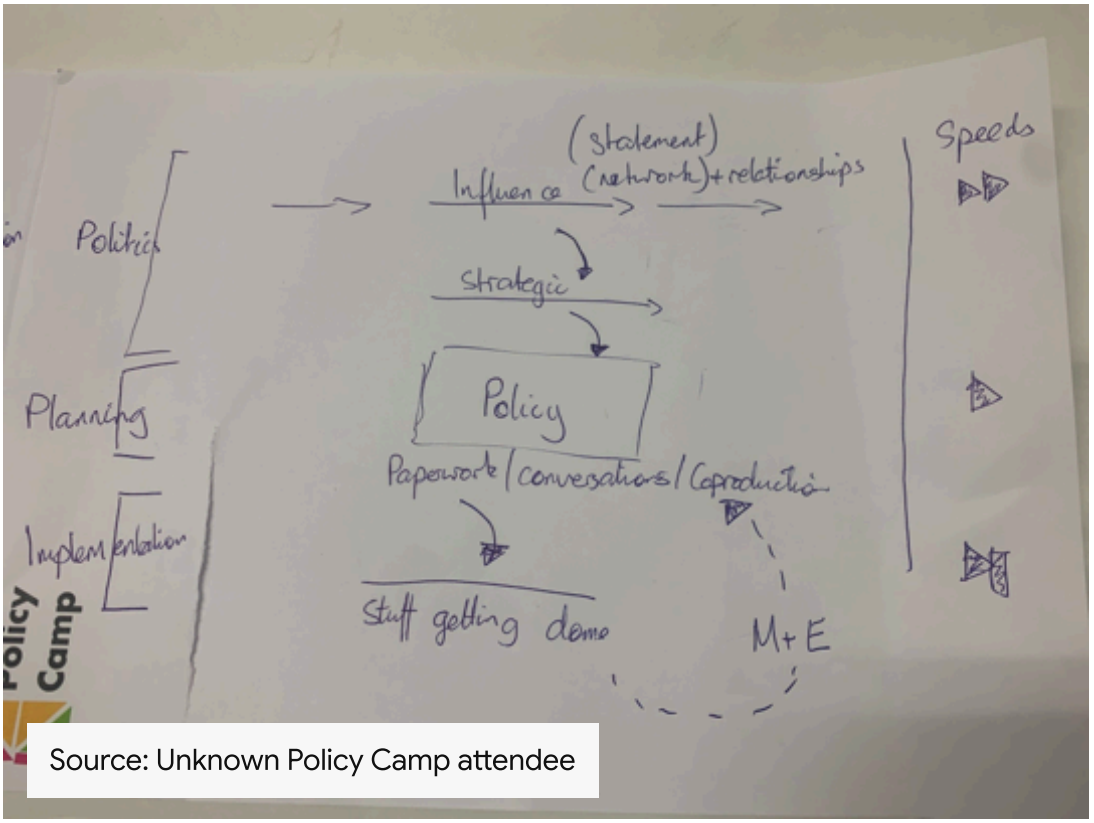
POLICY IN GENERAL

What is policy now?/Taking politics out of policy (Session 1, SQG1)

This group conceptualised policymaking as a process with four layers: influence, strategy (both 'political'), policy itself (a planning layer), and an implementation layer.

Many policies never get below the influence and strategy layer. Politics and policy cannot be separated; you have to make the best of the system you find yourself in and the constraints you face. There is a lot of creativity needed in policymaking (although funding and time pressures can make this very difficult). There were varying perspectives on what policy is, based on experience and particularly different departmental or business needs. Some other key points from breakout group notes include the idea that devolution should lead to better policies as bodies are closer to the population, and local policy makers may develop more strategic and stable policies; that 'policy' and 'politics' is the same word in many European languages showing how connected they are; the difference between policy and strategy; and the vital role of politics in defining the public good.

Practical takeaways: The diagram for thinking about policy, below.



Source: Unknown Policy Camp attendee

Culture and leadership for long-term stewardship (Session 2, Haldane)

This pitch came from an interest in driving change through culture, especially in a new organisation and for regulatory outcomes; the concept of stewardship is acting with care towards customers, community and environment, with integrity (including honesty about trade-offs) and clarity. Stewardship is particularly novel for regulators, where the focus is often on failure and accountability – but stewardship can help support innovation and collaboration. There was some discussion about where challenges really sat – with regulators, or with politics (shifting political winds) or the civil service (high churn and a focus on crisis response). Regulators need a balance of skills and cross-profession challenge. Stewardship could link to place-based, community engagement approaches. There are interesting paradoxes and tensions, such as: needing a leader to shape the culture but also needing the right signals to attract them in the first place; getting direction from government versus the organisation needing independence and having space to shape itself; cultural priorities being handed down from above, which could lack meaning and empowerment; empowering regulators creating siloes across government; bringing in industry expertise without being captured; and ultimately, whether stewardship is helpful in striking a balance between innovation and risk.

Practical takeaways: John Seddon's white paper on governance, Doughnut Economics and Thomas Hale's *Long Problems* were all mentioned as being helpful.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

Building system resilience (Session 2, Blue)

This started by asking whether 'adaptability' was a better objective: resilient systems can still preserve poor outcomes. There was a lot of discussion of systems thinking: infrastructure is connected, you need to understand the impacts on systems elsewhere, and perhaps spare capacity could be borrowed from elsewhere in the system. There was an analogy with the human nervous system: healthy systems flex under pressure then recover, but systems permanently under stress lose that elasticity. There is a need for better intelligence (including real time data) across the system, not just better models. End users were brought back into discussion several times – 'who is affected if this system fails?' – and community felt like an important missing layer between individuals and central government in whole society resilience. There was also some worry about placing too much responsibility on citizens rather than fixing systems, a generally poor understanding of long-term risk and the UK's discomfort about having honest conversations around disruption. One conclusion was that community, trust and relationships are perhaps as important as infrastructure itself.

The WEIRD problem in policy research (Western, Educated, Industrial, Rich, Democratic) (Session 4, Rajani)

One person opened by saying that in academia, most of the data comes from people with the WEIRD political mindset – is it the same in policymaking? Are we designing for 75% of the population, with policies not speaking to the other 25%? NHS digital services assume a high degree of digital literacy; digital ID forgets the digitally excluded and the ID excluded (e.g. people with no passport); government has a responsibility to deal with the edge cases. Meeting people where they are could mitigate these problems – DSIT had a people's panel on digital ID (though these are expensive, and funding was only available because it was high profile). Hard to reach groups are hard to reach – we should think about new ways to reach them (practitioners, recruiting through video games where a lot of young men are, immersive research on the street). Data is often not joined up around people. How can you remove the friction for people to participate? Reimburse them; simpler processes. Reach out to the frontline and other stakeholders – not the usual suspects, you have to go to them, be IN the community, lean on other organisations (such as Citizens Advice). You need to know the community to engage with them. We have to think about non-default users and personas, and define them early on – otherwise we'll exclude them from the start – and think about iterative processes in making policy. With regulation, too (e.g. on tech), how do you ensure it helps the people it was introduced to help and not the same populations or corporations?

Eliminating blockers, sludge and bureaucratic friction (Session 4, Yellow)

This could be a 'slightly political discussion' as ministers often blame the civil service for being a blocker. You could run a 'sludge audit' of internal government processes (like HR, procurement, etc). Processes often exist to minimise risk, to ensure the right people are involved, to avoid overspending of public money and prevent risk to the public – but processes are often not removed once the risk has subsided, plug into an existing blame culture, are disempowering for staff, are used to protect teams and budgets, and are not accompanied by discussions on the acceptable level of risk. Often, process is used to address problems of cultural capability. People can try new things – but without spending money, at low risk and inside existing processes. Covid PPE spend is a counter example (costing a huge amount of money as processes were bypassed); political decisions sometimes override processes if it's known they won't pass existing decision gates. A bit of friction can be useful to help make people realise they don't need the thing after all. Compliance teams don't want to work collaboratively – they just want to know if you've met the gate exactly.

Practical takeaways: you could conduct a 'sludge audit'; there might be a user research opportunity to measure the administrative burden on civil servants; you can put costs on things (e.g. 'how much is this 20-person meeting costing?') using online tools.

DEVOLUTION

Nested policy making – efficient policy making across central, local and devolved government (Session 2, Yellow)

This session explored how central, local and devolved government can work together more effectively to develop and deliver policy. Key themes were creating stronger connections between tiers of government, through greater transparency and involving local partners earlier in policy development (not just seeing them as delivery partners); three critical foundations for effective nested policymaking being clear accountability, clear end-to-end goals and purpose, and robust evaluation; bringing people together through creating spaces where different organisations and levels of government can come together (e.g. the planning sector, with shared outcome targets and dedicated targets); making policy more practical and deliverable through clearly-defined, achievable projects; recognising different local contexts through understanding local needs (supported by data – there was some discussion of the Covid-19 pandemic, and needing 'just enough' information to make decisions); finding the right balance between national top-down direction and community influence; learning from existing models like Pride in Place (while questioning how scalable different models are); and building policymaking capability (including convening, facilitation and consensus-building).

What does devolved power look like? (Session 3, Yellow)

This asked what good devolution looks like – reflecting local priorities and with decisions made at the appropriate level. We can't make blanket statements – different nations and regions have different decision-making powers; do we want mayoral authorities to all look the same or have different levels of power. There was discussion about responsibility and accountability: how to scrutinise, and a need to educate people on who makes what decisions. If people don't understand where power sits, how can they influence change? Informal networks are crucial to making these systems work. There are questions of scale: central government should negotiate prices with Microsoft, but local government should be able to use it how they like. There was also a discussion about inequality (will devolution create more of it?), and the need to avoid duplication – national government will need to be involved to share people and best practice across the country.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

Local government policy reorganisation (Session 1, Rajani)

Many people had been impacted by recent decisions on local government reorganisation, with concerns including the timescales for change and general confusion with multiple levels of reorganisation (national government, mayoral authorities, local authorities) – there is no chance to settle as change keeps coming (including political make-up of some councils). What would happen if councils came together with different policies in the same area? We should learn from the councils that are going first, share best practice and pick the best policies. Change can bring opportunities but also grieving. There was discussion about parish councils, ranging from the democratic deficit (some members are co-opted) becoming more acute if they become more visible, to protecting grants by providing them through the parish rather than soon-to-be-abolished councils.

Practical takeaways: in the absence of funding, Pride in Place could help – the boards ensured the right people were in the room at the right time; people also wanted more training for councillors; and the Local Government Association can help, for example in convening events.

Letting go! How can we remove the urge to control so that good policy can emerge naturally? (Session 1, Wilkins)

This session explored how often, government's instinct is to respond to problems by tightening control through targets, oversight and closer management. However, this urge often holds back good outcomes and inhibits the capacity and agency of communities, professionals, markets and places. The current devolution agenda is one part of this, but where else does the urge to control hold back good outcomes, and in practice what can be done to build the trust that allows for the relinquishing of control? Key themes and tensions included picking winners versus emergent approaches and market innovation; giving professionals autonomy within agreed structures; enabling frontline staff to control the service; avoiding policy imposition and policy-as-a-straitjacket; confidence with uncertainty and trust in practitioners; power dynamics and economies of scale (what is the right size for a place?); consistency versus deviance and political problems from postcode lotteries; problems from devolving power to market players by giving them outcomes but not telling them how to deliver; minimum standards versus detailed targets; and methods for dealing with the state of complexity which exists between order and chaos.

Practical takeaways: suggested reading included Hilary Cottam's *Radical Help* and *The Work We Need* (on good work); Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons*; *Stewardship* by Peter Block; the Cynefin framework for working in complexity; Kinship Works and Local Trust's *Civic Rewilding* for evidence on success in a UK context; the SCARF model and Leadership Mindtraps for understanding how our brains protect and reward our thinking and emotions; and trying some experiments (make a proposal for change with a decision date for continuing it; if rejected, reduce the ask by half; choose people, scope or duration).

WORKING TOGETHER

Frontline policy making – how can policy makers collaborate with frontline workers (Session 1, Yellow)

Some of the challenges in doing this include the capacity to engage from frontline services themselves (time, bandwidth, overwhelmed by delivery), local government being on the ground but not having time for strategic conversation, and siloes between different parts of local (let alone) central government. Opportunities for collaboration included local networks helping interest groups engage with central government; funding and leadership development being brought to communities and investing in them; being able to shadow teams on the frontline (where convenient for them); removing practical barriers such as money for train fares; building trusted partnerships where central government is giving back, and where expectations are managed and communicated; being collaborative, not adversarial, and working together to system-level targets; pinpointing individuals who can represent wider needs and views; and using innovative approaches.

Practical takeaways: Policy Lab's work, including giving a camera to film a 'day in the life'; using WhatsApp voice notes to review the front line experience directly after the interaction; using co-design methods and understand that you can go deep with a small number of people rather than having to involve everyone; using legislative theatre to act out scenarios and test what works.

Unhappy bedfellows? Policy and digital delivery - delivering fast? (Session 3, SQG1)

The question here was 'what is hard, and what would help both digital and policy collaborate better around outcomes?' Trusted relationships were key – aligning plans and programmes to be complementary, allocating time to collaborate (and sharing benefits stories to encourage this), and bringing in people as early as possible to build mutual understanding between digital teams and particular policy areas. 'Multidisciplinary teams are BOMB', and Test Learn and Grow is trying to do this at the moment – humility, and building psychological safety to work together is important. Is there an equivalent of the GDS Service Standard and Service Assessment for policy? Could the existing standard be better aligned with departmental governance? (The Home Office has five tests internally.) Would ministers be signed up for this? (There was a sense that they are interested in user research and solving hard problems.) Staff churn can make maintaining knowledge and culture difficult. Policymakers should be seen as system convenors, where curiosity is key: they should promote this at a working level (including to ministers) so frontline insights and new thinking goes all the way up the food chain.

Practical takeaways: TPXimpact's Market-shaping Playbook for Policymakers has advice on multidisciplinary working; whether there are policy equivalents or applications of the GDS Service Standard and Service Assessment.

Government and civil society (Session 2, Rajani)

This began with a reference to the Civil society covenant, designed to reset how government works with civil society. There were some examples (mainly from the Home Office) about working with community organisations, the department being able to bring together different perspectives, having owners for civil society engagement in each team and the importance of building relationships rather than engaging on a transactional basis. There was some discussion of increased hostility towards (e.g.) councillors because of social media, and other shifts in expectations and trust between public and politics. Some pieces of advice for civil society in being useful to central government included coalitions presenting an easily understood collective voice; keeping to contract; treating civil servants as people and thinking about the give and take (what civil society can do for the civil servant as well); and being transparent about trade-offs and having realistic expectations (e.g. for new policies). Civil servants should try to put themselves in the shoes of the people who are lobbying from the civil society side.

Practical takeaways: There is a toolkit for local authorities on how to combat online hate.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

FUTURES

Long termism in the age of high churn and social media (Session 1, Haldane)

This highlighted current trends away from long-term thinking about policies and their benefits towards short-termism. Drivers include the media cycle and not providing an environment for risk-taking and innovation, an absence of national conversation, futures and foresight teams not being well-known, churn in both politics and the civil service, uncertainty, and having the right evidence and expertise; AI slop making genuine engagement between government and public more difficult was also raised. Solutions include closer working between policy and comms, civic technology and getting people in the room helping to ensure genuine two-way conversation between government and publics, cross-party working, more futures thinking and capacity building, and being more explicit about evidence and long-term trade-offs in comms.

Practical takeaways: examples of how to do things differently included Taiwan's approach to public engagement, Wales' future generations commissioner, futures and foresight work, and calls for a select committee for the future.

Policy design for longer lives and future generations (Session 3, SR11)

'Bring back the village' was the overarching theme of this discussion. Other themes included: longer lives and fewer births change dynamics; the 'middle generation' is caring for both much older relatives and grandchildren, and with fewer young people to support them; there is a growing dependence on technology for care (is society becoming virtual?); community (council estates show strong bonds, but funding for community centres is shrinking, will there be any social offline spaces left for young people and where can generations mix?); hopes and fears for the next generation (hopes including home ownership and intergenerational learning, fears a loss of community and a need to turn away from social media); housing and urban design (a lack of shared spaces, how to build a genuine community, the need for community-run third spaces where people spend time rather than money); pensions, care and policy, including whether pensions need redesigning and anxieties from young people about what their care will look like and the disproportionate policy power of older generations; and further observations on environmental uncertainty, a critique of income tax as the default lens for valuing people, whether we are too dependent on automation, and our society's fixation on the now rather than long-term planning.

Practical takeaways: the final point was to consider a dystopian 'futures thinking' exercise: think of the most extreme scenario of social estrangement if current trends continue unchecked. What does that world look like?

METHODS AND EVIDENCE

Behavioural science – real change or emperor's new clothes? (Session 1, SR11)

Behavioural science is an established and useful practice – it can sometimes be difficult to see change, but there are good examples (e.g. stopping smoking); it is a discipline, which allows us to test interventions and use it as a framework; there is a psychology to patterns of social behaviour, although it can sometimes be difficult to choose which behaviours to target (the root causes can be fragmented and may differ between people) and behaviour change may have different impacts on different people. There can be an emperor's new clothes feel at times – people continue to praise an approach which is false or worthless, and there are other ways (such as systems thinking) to approach issues. Real value may come through collaboration with other approaches and trying to evidence changes. There is a lack of understanding in ministerial decisions. In reality policy is a process – there is a behavioural part to that, but trust is a two-way street, is not just about control and is about emotional equity (behavioural science can assume the decision maker has all the evidence).

Practical takeaways: there was a book recommendation, which may have been *Reciprocity and the Art of Behavioural Public Policy* by Adam Oliver.

Co-creation/co-design – beyond 'the policymaker' (Session 4, Haldane)

This session asked what co-creation means, and from people's experiences, how it can be done well. Breakout groups came to the following thoughts: there is an array of cocreation (from 'just a roundtable' or a focus group, to actually giving people autonomy), there needs to be creativity, and there needs to be storytelling to have the greatest impact; knowledge sharing is vital (is this being done elsewhere? Is it already being done in our department?); you need the infrastructure in place to build relationships and trust; the professionalisation of codesign can lead to siloed working; and distinguishing between co-creating the what and co-creating the how, and being conscious of who is excluded from the process. One breakout group considered the pandemic and what codesign in a crisis looks like (perhaps working through third parties), the extent to which you can truly co-design once the problem has already been defined and how to work with communities (you may not be the right people but can you give the community the tools they need?), and the importance of being honest about the scope and managing expectations.

Lego serious play! How to do authentic participation? (Session 1, SR20)

This session demonstrated the Lego Serious Play methodology, starting with a two-minute exercise where participants were invited to build a tower starting with a flat platform and finished with a green flag. The variety of designs even with identical simple instructions shows how different people interpret and build with 'the same brick', and is useful for imagining workshops with diverse participants. People were then asked to build a Lego model representing a person they were designing for (persona), which ranged from asylum seekers to prison workers to bridges to housing; there was also a policymaker, modelled with plants growing on his feet (rooted/slow-moving within a lot going on) and a lightsaber (power/tools to act). The final exercise was to design a solution to some of the challenges highlighted, examples including scaffolding (representing better support structures) and a circular desk (designed to bring more people into the conversation).

Practical takeaways: Lego Serious Play as a technique, where participants describe what they've built in their own words and terms rather than technical or 'correct' language.

Is our obsession with evidence impacting quality policy making? (Session 2, Wilkins)

This started with the premise that it is not possible to measure impact in a complex system, and if we're not measuring impact, what are we left with? There was discussion about 'what gets measured gets managed' leading to perverse incentives; what we mean by 'evidence' (data, academic evidence); how politicians can ignore evidence, how it can be used to bolster pre-agreed positions, and how decisions can sometimes need to be based on political priorities; how gathering evidence can take time and sometimes prevent swifter action (and devolving control sometimes means acting ahead of the evidence); the need to tell stories and weave narrative, with context crucial for helping audiences empathise with evidence; and a narrow Western view of evidence (e.g. should we do more on measuring wellbeing?). Evidence should be seen as learning: we should change the question from 'did it work?' to 'should we change direction based on what we know?' (from lagging to leading); the need to share learnings when things haven't worked and the difficulties in admitting failure – academics are required to learn from failure, so policymakers should too, and Test Learn and Grow suggests this conversation is happening; the need for scaling to take into account the wider reasons for why a policy initiative has worked and scale those, rather than the initiative itself; central government's role in sharing learning but also the need for local knowledge of local factors; and concerns about whether there are enough mechanisms to gather evidence, and whether evidence from other countries can be 'lifted and shifted' or if not learning is a matter of national pride.

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Beyond the productivity narrative – how can AI empower policy makers (Session 1, Blue)

Themes included: the need to think about what problem AI is actually solving, and whether you need to redesign work before introducing AI; that it risks producing more policy, more quickly, rather than better policy; that AI should be seen as a tool rather than a replacement for policymakers, and that officials need the capability and human judgment to challenge outputs that are not neutral and can be biased; that AI can support analysis, could widen participation for groups often excluded from consultation and could help surface local knowledge – but needs to be designed deliberately to do so with a wide range of perspectives; and the importance of digital sovereignty, given the reliance on overseas models. One participant compared AI to a microwave – these didn't replace ovens, but found their place. Technology alone cannot solve public engagement challenges, and the biggest challenge with AI might be helping people understand where it adds value and where it doesn't.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

The robots are coming – how is AI adding value to your work? (Session 3, Blue)

A wide-ranging discussion covered some departmental use cases of AI; the need to separate AI being used poorly from poor governance and assurance; how the public are using AI to interact with government, which has benefits but is also threatening to overwhelm systems (and with government using AI to respond, is just computers talking to each other); the importance of expertise in being able to use and scrutinise AI well (what happens if there is no such expertise?); bias; the one-way relationship with Copilot, i.e. we can't get information about how the civil service is using it out of it, and we should have more information about how data is being used; digital sovereignty; how most organisations are focusing on optimisation not transformation; the need to maintain scepticism since AI is designed to agree with us; and how the public will perceive greater AI use by government, leading to another trust issue.

Policy skills and capabilities – what will the policy profession look like in 2035? (Session 4, SQG1)

This started by asking what skills and behaviours will we need for systems leadership, but largely focused on a second question – what impact is AI going to have on the profession? This covered how policy professionals will use it (useful for administrative tasks but less so for policy activities – many people in government are unaware they are doing policy), the need for humans to remain in the loop (including on accountability), whether AI can free up capacity and time (for example, for more public engagement, evidence generation and idea generation), and the impact on junior roles and career progression.

AI safety plus the AI de-skilling problem (Session 4, Wilkins)

There was concern that with people using LLMs to write basic emails and read reports for them, we are degrading our writing abilities and our comprehension; people are less critical of AI outputs. A counterpoint: we have been through technological change before; the loss of our ability to do long division has not been bad for society, and calculators were a useful innovation. A counter to this: LLMs are different; critical thinking, writing and reading are important skills for engaging with society, and we are outsourcing the act of thinking. There was further discussion about the impact on recruitment; AI sovereignty and our reliance on US models; climate impacts (water and energy use); whether LLMs are inevitable or a tech bubble; the emotional and relational costs of using sycophantic chatbots as therapists and romantic partners; the need to teach AI skills; the impact on women and girls, and vulnerable groups; whether we should treat AI as a public health issue; Silicon Valley being driven by profit and currently running a loss to lock users in; and the need for government to set out a proactive, not reactive, vision.

CLIMATE CHANGE

Climate change mitigation (Session 3, Rajani)

Some of the themes discussed included: the importance of mitigation alongside adapting to climate change; why banning private jets (an easy win?) hasn't happened (expected reactions from the press and business); with so many different contributors to the problem and so many different teams working on it, how to collaborate and where to do *something* to help; the difficulties of selling mitigation (people to care for right now) as the most financially sustainable approach; the role of national government in creating ways to invest for the long-term and working on the international stage (harder than five years ago, especially with the US); systems change starts with one person then a movement, but we're not stepping up or being bold/curious enough; heatwaves may be landing the issue with people; the burden on developing countries and the UK's historical responsibility for emissions; if you can't appeal to producers' better instincts, then make them pay; how councils are dealing with heatwaves; what local authorities can do without central government, how the two tiers work together (including the need for more collaboration), the practical barriers that exist and the potential for devolution to make a difference; how to balance mitigation and adaptation and where to prioritise; and what regulators can do, such as monitoring emissions and playing a role in incentives.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

Towards carbon-free international travel (Session 2, SR20)

This asked the question: how do we reduce the carbon emissions of international travel? There is a role for the maritime industry (which has committed to decarbonise and achieve net zero by 2050); making international travel by boats cheaper could help, if it's easier to decarbonise than aviation (where green tech does not exist). Ideas included a frequent flyer/private jet levy; subsidising international rail travel and taxing flights (France taxes flights to subsidise rail, but has high speed rail); subsidising rail travel in the UK (it can be more expensive than international travel) which would also promote regional growth; and incentivise foreign travellers to enter the UK via green transport. There was discussion about the need for good comms (including celebrities and influencers), and that electrified transport will be cheaper, providing a cost-of-living angle.

SPECIFIC POLICY AREAS

Adult social care reform (Session 3, Haldane)

This opened with a range of statistics demonstrating the urgency of action, including 80% of council spending being spent on children's and adult social care (outside education). There have been 27 white papers on how to fix it in 27 years; Andy Burnham has revived the idea of a National Care Service; the Casey Commission is in progress. There are lots of big system issues across multiple organisations. Do the multiple white papers suggest solutions are known but money is lacking? There was discussion about the workforce, learning from palliative care on collaborative working, measuring the administrative burden (to show how much people have to join up separate government teams themselves), the importance of prevention, how we (don't) value care work, what a post-Casey market for social care could look like, and why the Treasury doesn't want to own semi-clinical funding decisions. Reference was made to Wales' Social Services and Wellbeing Act (on eligibility of care, coproduction and digitisation) and Scotland. There were further points about whether a central digital service could make efficiency savings without impacting local decision-making, how to shift from 'tragedy-driven delivery' to long-term strategic planning, and the need for more interdependence, including data sharing between services and more policy planning for landing specific objectives such as loneliness, housing and poverty.

Practical takeaways: Hilary Cottam's *Radical Help* and James Plunkett's Kinship Works on local support networks.

Skills, education and employment – the NEET crisis (Session 4, Blue)

This focused on people Not in Education, Employment or Training (NEETs). Points raised included: becoming a NEET starts with lower school attendance; AI is exacerbating what is already a complex issue, through removing jobs (all while government is encouraging AI use) and the impact on mental health from AI chatbots and social media; young people are negative about future job prospects and AI – we need a more positive narrative (there are opportunities, they're just changing), which government should be able to deliver; it may be harder for young people to access work experience (e.g. basic retail, paper round); the Sheffield Community Mission Challenge (a Test Learn and Grow project with DfE and the local council) is focusing on data sharing around NEETs, as councils often don't have reliable data on who they are – devolution provides a big opportunity to get this right but teams need to be funded; devolution could also lead to more local career opportunities; we need to build awareness around other sectors and opportunities and make these jobs attractive to young people; and we need to transfer the knowledge and experience of retiring staff to younger people.

High street policy (Session 4, SR11)

Local government has limited powers to manage their high streets – how can councils better steward their local high streets? There are ways around local plans (even if they say, for example, no gambling shops). Smart data could help drive better decisions. There might be some things around planning (densification – convert some things to housing). 'People get the high street they can afford'. Could we take over units and turn them into public amenities? What are the metrics for measuring the success of a high street? Levers for improvement include planning and the tax regime, but does a local authority need to buy every lease to actually be able to do anything? Some places (Camden, Kilburn, Brick Lane) retain a strong local identity – how do they do it? If local councils are to be stewards of place, they need a way to manage it – and whatever is done has to be community-led, helped by central government. When asked to wave a magic wand (not money) to solve things, answers included amending the Gambling Act; seeing vacant units and the degradation of the high street as a public health problem; make better expert cases; and devolving decisions on e.g. tourist tax and ringfencing money for the public realm.

How can tech improve women's health? (Session 2, SR11)

This posited that there is a space for technology to be helpful for women's health and could be used to reclaim the health journey, but there are multiple problems. These include data not always being inclusive, biased towards men and used in troubling ways (e.g. smart watches identifying that a woman is pregnant); cynicism around tech and money in health; inequity in the use of technology; difficulties in accessing some data (e.g. paywalls); limited research on some conditions, and a legacy of medical misogyny manifesting through algorithms; and the biases of tech companies. The need to build trust (and transparency) around the use of health data was a common theme, and the importance of institutional trust in this; there was also discussion of hard to access services leading to people using AI to diagnose themselves, with impacts on trust in medical professionals; accessibility, inclusion and design (with proper representation) are all important.

Practical takeaways: Caroline Criado Perez's *Invisible Women*.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

PRESENTATION: TEST, LEARN AND GROW

Once all the unconference sessions were done, and just before the final 'giveaway and takeaway' exercise to wrap up the day, we had a presentation and Q&A with the Cabinet Office's Test, Learn and Grow team.

The presenters were **Jess Hunt** (head of product for Test, Learn and Grow) and **Nigel Keohane** (head of strategy for Test, Learn and Grow). You can learn more on the Test, Learn and Grow blog or via their newsletter and LinkedIn community.

This is a lightly edited transcript, incorporating images of the slides.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

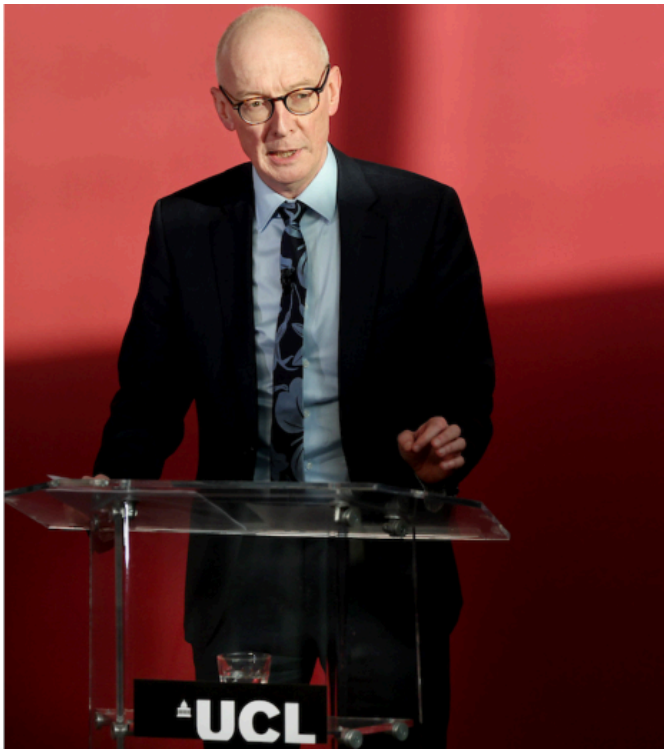
Jess Hunt: Thanks for having us here today. We're representatives from the Test, Learn and Grow programme and we're going to spend the next 20 minutes or so giving some background on the programme and the work that we do, and hopefully have a bit of an opportunity for questions at the end.

So to set the scene for the Test, Learn and Grow programme: there's a general acknowledgement across political parties and also with the public that public services aren't really delivering the outcomes that people need in their lives. And so the programme is set up on the premise that to do things differently, we need to bring a real humility to policy making and not dive in with the assumption that we have all of the answers from the onset.

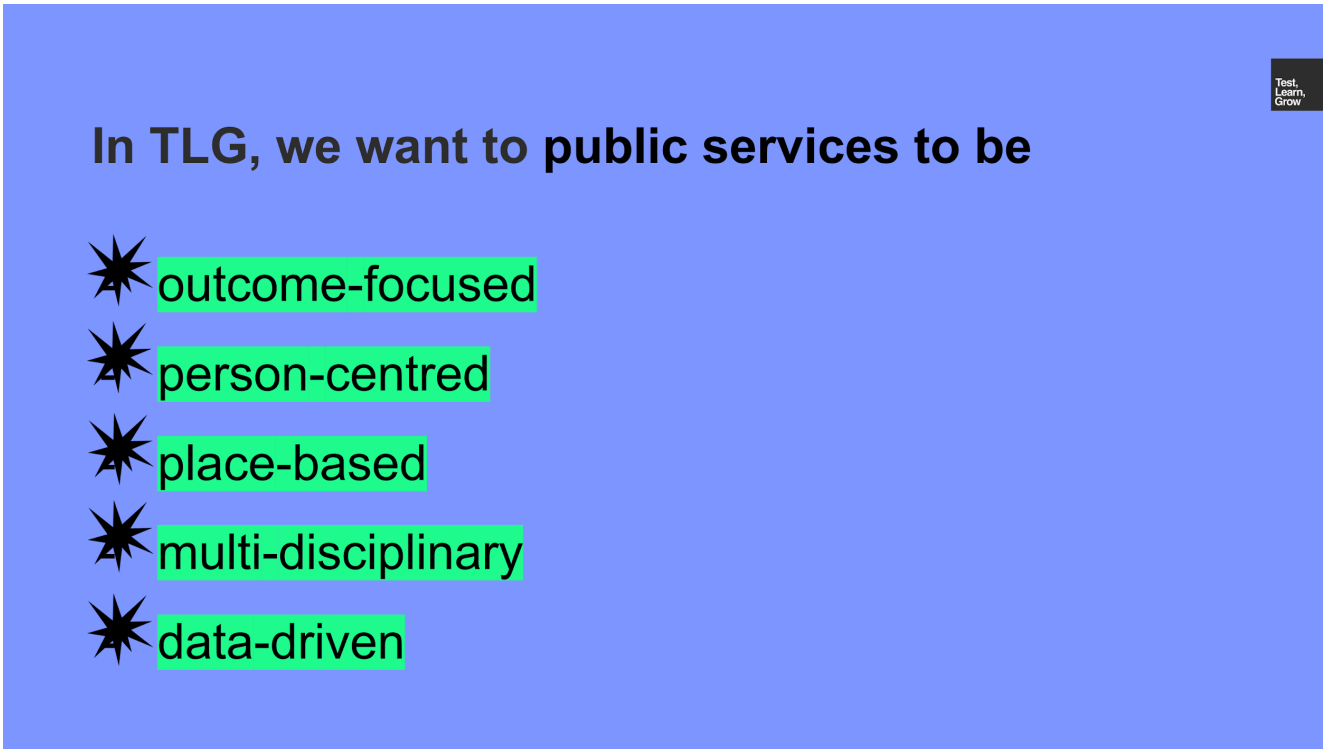
“Test it. Fix the problems. Change the design. Test it again. Tweak it again… For as long as you provide the service.

Suddenly, the most important question isn’t, ‘How do we get this right the first time?’. It’s ‘How do we make this better by next Friday?”

Rt Hon Pat McFadden, December 2024



The Test, Learn and Grow programme was announced by Pat McFadden, who was overseeing the Cabinet Office at that time. It was announced at the end of 2024 and the programme was launched in 2025. As you'll see in this quote, Pat was talking about how it's trying to change the onus from not, ‘how do we get this right the first time?’ but ‘how do we make it better by focusing more on learning?’, and the Test, Learn and Grow methodology really focuses on identifying the riskiest assumptions, the things that we don't know but need to get right in order to make our work a success. And then it focuses on testing and really exploring whether those assumptions we made are realised in practice, and building and learning as you go.



In the Test, Learn and Grow programme there are five core focuses or principles that define our work. First, that we are outcome-focused. We really are focused on trying to understand or be guided by the outcomes that real people want to see in their lives, and kind of working backwards to understand why things may not be achieving that in practice.

The work is person-centred. We really want to understand how services are delivered for real people and get that feedback from people into the process.

Our programme is place-based, which is really exciting as we're working with 10 local authorities across the country on our accelerator programme, and lots of others through the kind of wider movement work.

Our work is also truly multi-disciplinary. So we're really not just nodding as being multi-disciplinary, but trying to bring different experts together to draw on different skill sets.

And it's also data-driven, so that we're really focused on quantifying impact and understanding trends in outcome.

Test and Learn is a way of working, used to deliver user-centred services that improve over time.



As I've kind of pointed to, Test and Learn is a way of working that really centres on user-centred design, user-centred services, and improving over time. The focus is on starting small, recognizing that we don't necessarily know what works in practice so we want to test and fail or adapt quite quickly, and then scale up on the basis of learning about what works. So that's the methodology that's really at the heart of what we're doing.

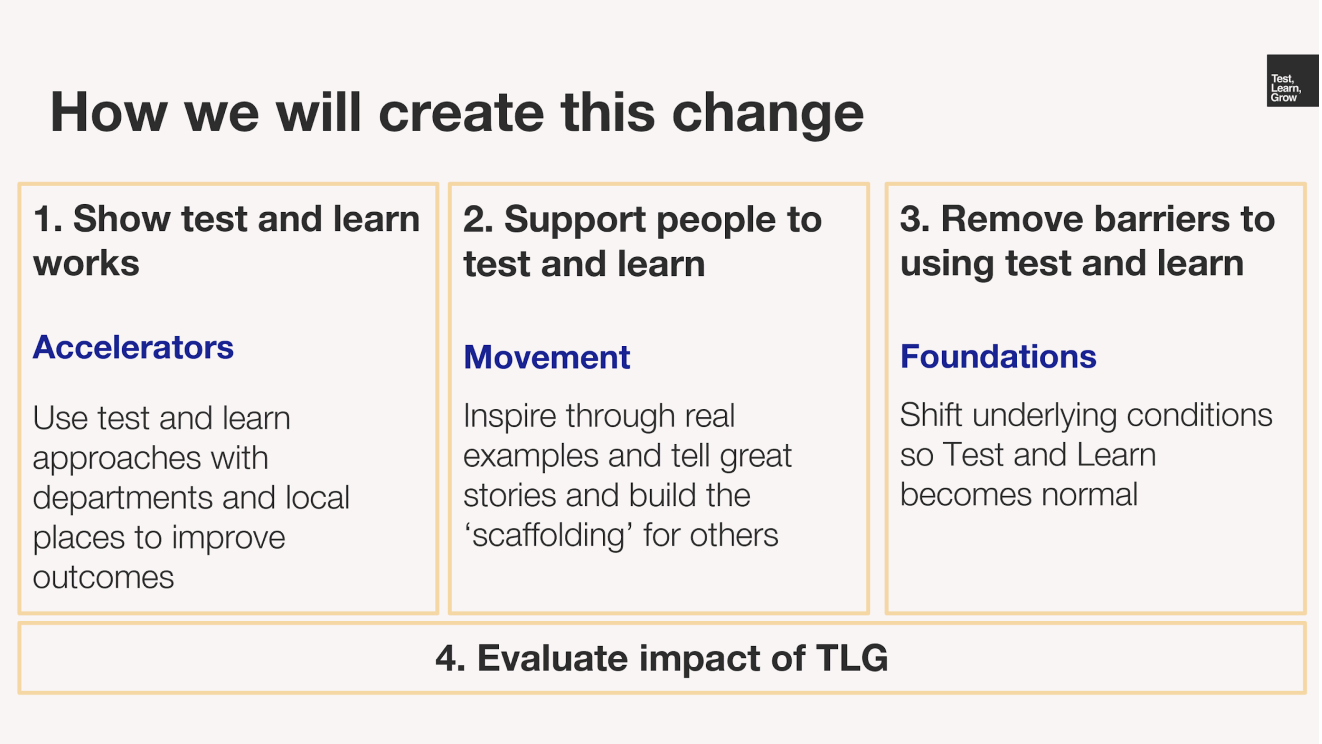
Nigel Keohane:

Test, Learn and Grow is a programme that applies Test and Learn at scale, to understand the conditions for success

It builds on what works across the public sector – to create a movement for system change



I'm just going to say a bit about the programme specifically. But we're not here to say, 'here, you know, we're the people doing Test and Learn' because we know that this sort of practice actually is quite prevalent, especially in local public services, but we're trying to essentially demonstrate which services it works in and also try and promote that across government, this way of working.



The way we do that is in three main parts of work. One is through the work that Jess was describing – we'll say a bit more about that, which is our Test and Learn schemes and we call those accelerators. So we want to show that this way of working works and explore which types of public services it works in and how.

Secondly we want to do that learning bit – try to sort of inspire people to do Test and Learn, but also connect them. So that's trying to bring people from local government, central government, civil society, bring those people together. We have something called the TLG Network which is a LinkedIn community, but behind that we also run lots of events. For example, we did one on data sharing: how do you get to grips with data sharing as an enabler for working in this sort of way? So we run all sorts of events. We want to build that movement across government.

And then the third way is about removing the barriers. And I think this really aligns with what we heard from the new prime minister about, essentially, the new ways of working, trying to rewire the system so that it's much more in favour of people on the front line who have that expertise, local decision makers who can then respond much better to what users actually want.

Jess:

Working across England

Accelerator	Place
Family support services	Northumberland
	Manchester
Neighbourhood health	Plymouth
	Liverpool
Employment outcomes	Wakefield
VAWG prevention	London
Transitions to employment for young people with SEND	Nottingham
	Sandwell
AI and data assistance to the frontline	Barnsley
	Essex



So part of the programme is focused on delivering accelerators. We have six accelerators. Each accelerator is focused on using the Test and Learn methodology to really try to drive progress against some of the most complex, biggest challenges the country faces. I'll run through each and give top lines on each.

One is focused on trying to really enhance our family support services and driving progress on a good level of development, so early years outcomes. We're working with Northumberland and Manchester to do that.

One's focused on neighbourhood health. So obviously the government is focused on really trying to shift care out of the NHS and into neighbourhoods and there's a number of delivery uncertainties that come with that. In Plymouth we're looking at how neighbourhood health models of care can improve cardiovascular outcomes; in Liverpool, we're looking at how we can design neighbourhood health care to focus on children's respiratory outcomes.

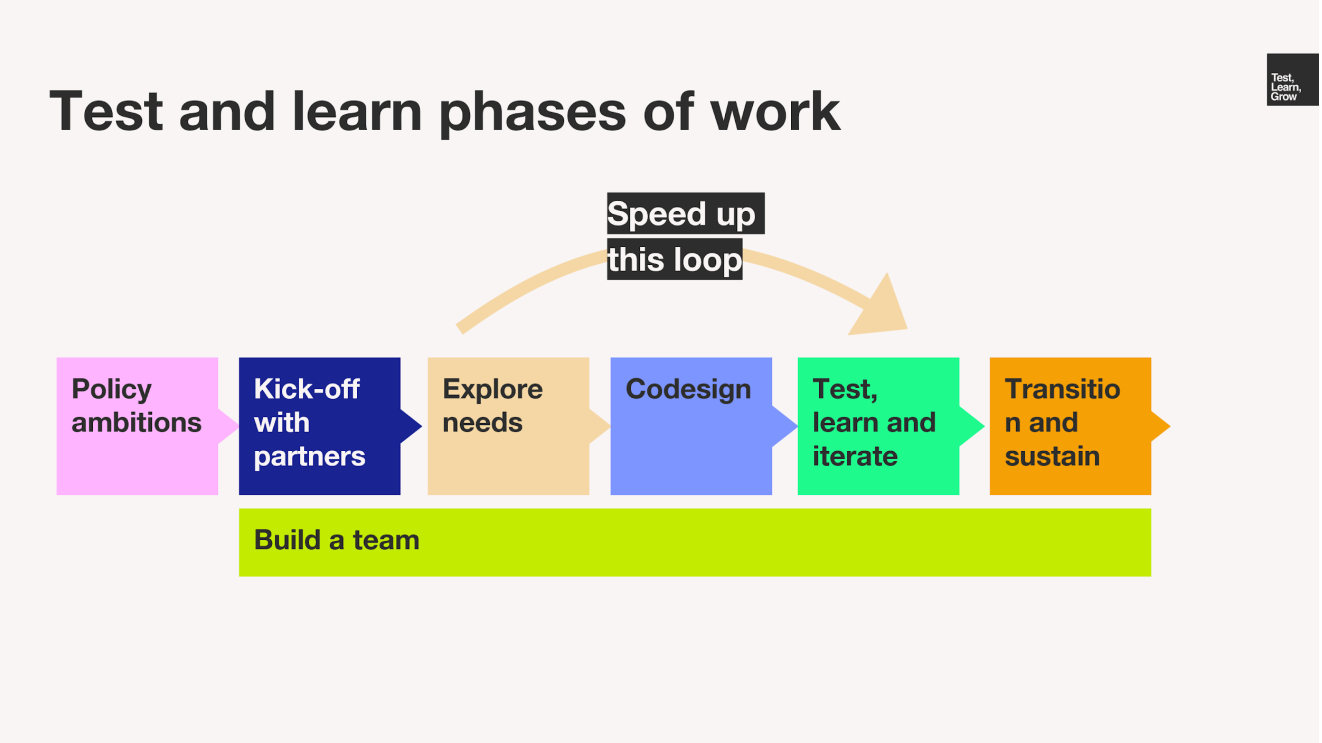
One of our accelerators is focused on improving employment outcomes, specifically reducing the number of young people who are NEET and that is really aligned with the Milburn review priorities.

One's focused on reducing violence against women and girls and we're partnered with Islington.

One's focused on the transitions to employment for young people with SEND, where we're working with Nottingham and Sandwell.

And the final one, we're looking at AI solutions to really improve outcomes in children's services in partnership with Barnsley and Essex.

So as you'll see, we've really taken on some quite complex, nasty challenges and looking at how we can partner with place to align, set the priorities of central government with local place priorities to find routes in to drive progress on these areas.



This is how we conceptualize the Test and Learn phases of work within our accelerators. So we start by really trying to understand the policy ambitions – like, the overarching outcome – that we're looking to drive in each of those areas. These then become really focused, building really strong relationships with our place partners, understanding what each of those local authorities see as real priorities and opportunities in those areas, and with our place partners we've also been looking at building a team where we're bringing experts and specialists from the programme. We're bringing product specialists, design specialists, analysts and partnering with people who are real experts in the local area and delivery.

We then spend a considerable amount of time really trying to understand local needs, what people and delivery staff see as the priorities in the area and then co-designing solutions. And after the codesign, it goes to the space of testing, learning and iterating and that loop continues until we feel that we've either got a really strong solution, or perhaps we've kind of parked something if we're not getting good signals. And then we're looking at how we can transition and sustain solutions that show effective promise.

Neighbourhood health example

The principles that underpin the **Neighbourhood Health** reforms;

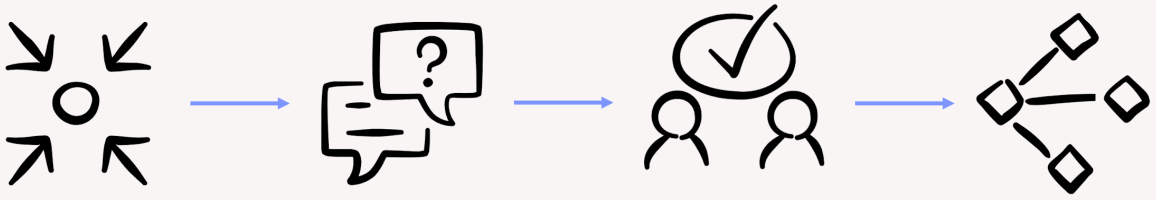
- **from hospital to community**
- **from analogue to digital**
- **from sickness to prevention**

represent a radical shift to the current model for delivering healthcare.



To put a bit of a spotlight on one of our accelerators: I mentioned before that one is focused on neighbourhood health. Trying to move care, potentially, from hospitals to community is quite a radical shift and as I mentioned before, there's a number of particular uncertainties that come with that. So we're really trying to focus on developing bottom-up solutions and testing challenges with local partners.

Targeted respiratory clinics



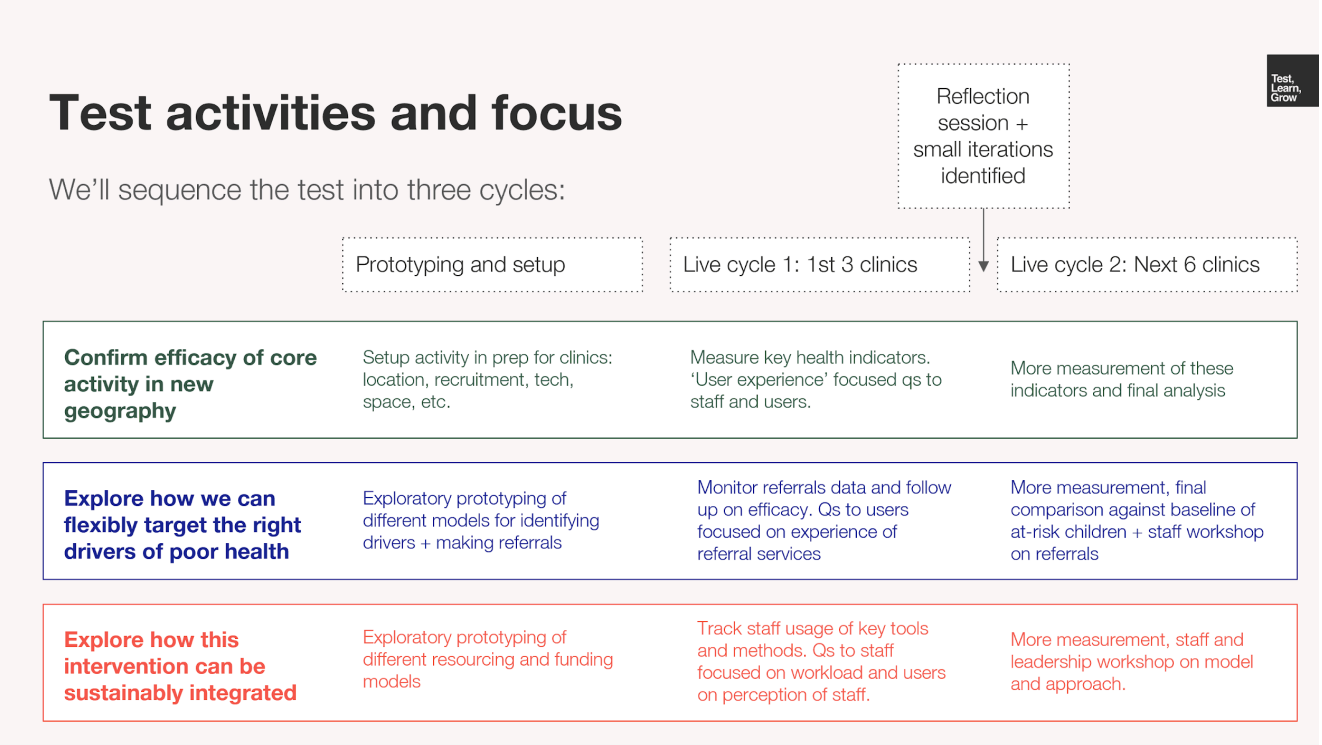
Identify a cohort of local 0-5s at risk of serious respiratory issues and contributory factors

Proactively invite children and their caregivers to clinics via SMS/letter/phone

Review medication and share tips on symptom management and medication use at clinic

Refer people experiencing contributory factors to holistic services that can help

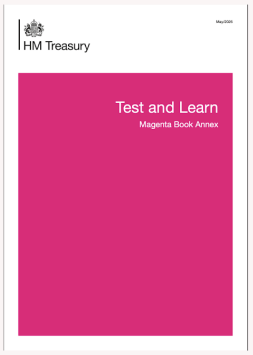
We're going to focus on our work with Liverpool. The kind of solution that we're really looking to Test and Learn about is respiratory health clinics, which focus on providing more holistic signposting to support that goes beyond medical support and also trying to support prevention to reduce the number of kids that show up in A&E. So in this accelerator we're really focusing on how we can Test and Learn around how you identify the relevant cohort, how you get the relevant cohort children to show and their parents to show up at services, how you can make sure that support is really targeted and tailored to these, and then making sure that that's delivering the outcomes that we wanted to.



This is quite a detailed slide so I'm not going to go into it in detail, but broadly: this test is set up in three phases, from prototyping, into a life cycle one where we're working on three clinics, to scaling up what we're learning. And we're really looking to build learning on three dimensions: understanding more about the setup of these clinics, understanding more about the services that were on offer and making sure that really hones to local needs, and then, finally, what we can learn about how you would scale up that offer.

We are driving change in the system

Test, Learn, Grow

Place-based Budget pilots	Community Mission Challenges	Data sharing	T&L guidance in Magenta book
Partnering with MHCLG to pilot pooling local public service budgets in 5 local areas to give places the flexibility to redesign services. Announced at Budget 2025.	Three successful pilots delivered bringing civil servants and local public sector partners together in place to focus on a public service challenge at pace.	Helped Sheffield access education dataset and now supporting roll out to MSAs. Wider work on case studies and guidance	

Nigel: So I was going to say this about the growing bit of test, learn and grow: what we're trying to do there, as well as sort of build a movement and interest in it, we're trying to rewire the system so that essentially, it's much easier for people to work in that way.

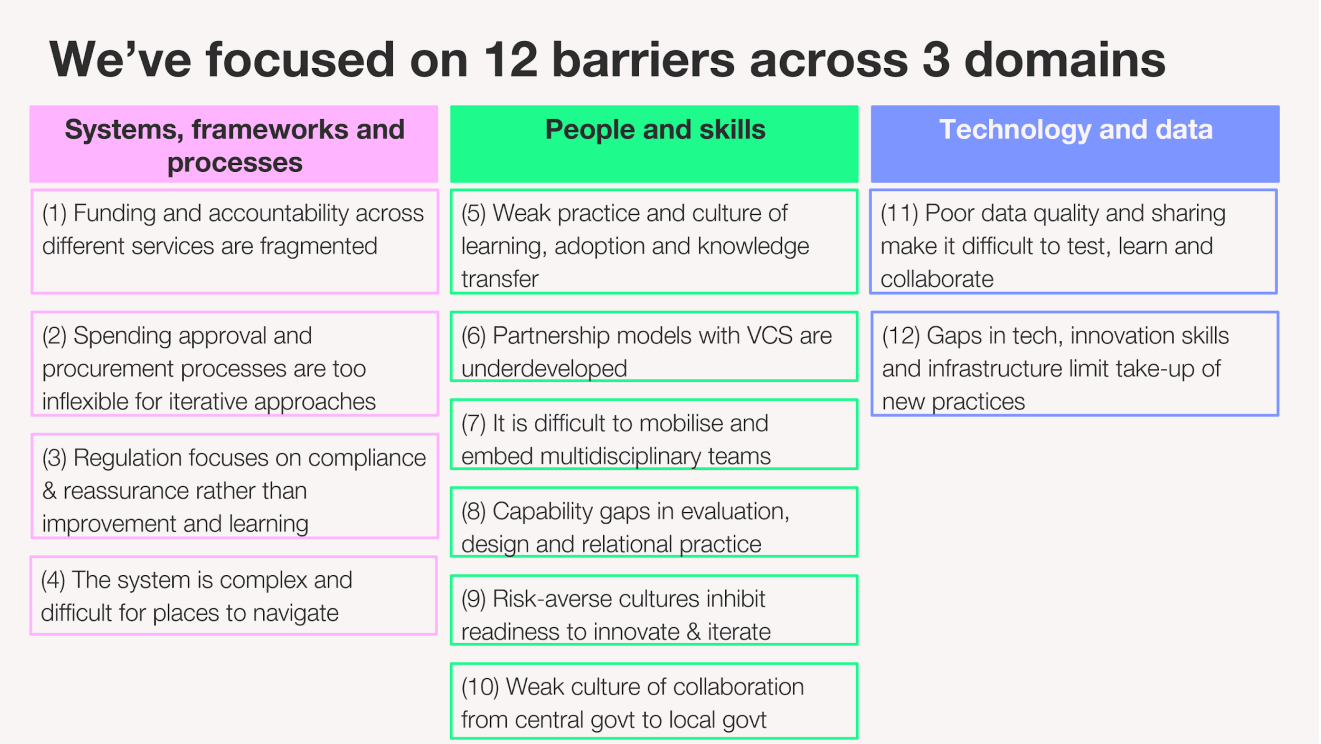
We've been thinking about: what are the things that get in the way? What are the barriers (and I'll come on to those in a sec)?

I was going to say this about some of the work streams that we're doing to try and address this. The first one is something called place-based budget pilots, and this is trying to think about: well, all of the resource and all of the public spending that goes into a local area at the moment, that's attached to all sorts of different departmental initiatives, has all sorts of requirements on how it's spent. How about if we gave all of that resource to the local area and they had more flexibility about how they use it to respond to what citizens need? And that would allow them to have a much more iterative Test and Learn approach to public services.

Another challenge that we've confronted is the fact – I suppose it's the culture and the practices of people who work in central government like Jess and I – the fact that most civil servants aren't really used to working with local partners in place. But there is a big initiative to try and move the civil service out of London, and obviously the prime minister is very interested in that as well now, and we've got some initiatives to deliberately get civil servants working much more closely with the local public sector where they work to try and address very specific public service challenges.

And then just to mention two more issues. One is around data sharing. It's probably familiar to a lot of you, but the way that data is held in all sorts of organizational compartments (as it were) means that we can't get the data to know who we should be trying to help. We can't learn what's working quickly. So we're doing lots to try and free up that data, make it more available, so it can be shared across the public sector.

And then finally: in government, we're a bit obsessed with different coloured books. We have the Green Book for how you spend money. We've got the Teal Book for how you run projects. And we've also got something called the Magenta Book, which is how you should evaluate public services. And we managed to get Test and Learn guidance into that Magenta Book.



And I'm just going to run through – not all of these barriers that we've got here, but I just wanted to describe the headings that we're looking at. So the first one's around the systems, frameworks and processes. I mentioned about the way that money flows. I think the way money flows affects accountability, affects incentives.

There's a big set of challenges around people and skills. Do we have the capabilities to be working in these ways locally and nationally? Do we have the sort of the incentives for people to innovate and take risks? I think that's a big question mark.

And then on the right-hand side, questions about technology and data.



The final slide from us is about building connection. Actually, today is a great example of building connections (thank you for the opportunity). As I mentioned, we have a Test, Learn and Grow Network – we will find a way of advertising that to all of you so that you can join if you'd like to. But it's a really important bit of our philosophy, the 'Learn' bit, how do we make sure that it's easy for people to share their ideas? How is it easy for people to learn and adopt best practice from each other? That is intrinsic to what we're here to do.

So that's us, but we've got a bit of time for questions. And it's great to hear people's thoughts on the sort of agenda that we've been describing today. Thank you.

Audience question 1: Thank you. Great presentation. Part of Test, Learning and Growing – growing has to be the most difficult part. How do you envisage the ability to grow at the start?

Audience question 2: As a central government institution (the Ministry of Justice) it's very interesting to follow what you're delivering together at a local level, and very interested to think about how we can take those same approaches and embed them into what we do in central government. I don't know if that's on your agenda as Test, Learn and Grow or if we can learn from you and then take that on, but I'd love to hear your thoughts on how everything you're doing can be an exemplar that can then be shared through central government.

Audience question 3: I was just thinking about how a lot of this correlates to user-centred design and product development. So is there anything that you found to be different when this is applied to policy development?

Nigel: Those are great questions, thank you. On the growing one, I'd say we're taking a multi-pronged approach. I think part of it is trying to rewire the system, which should affect, I suppose, everyone. The second thing is about building the connections, and then the third thing is about capability building, which I think is really important now we've got a strong devolution agenda. We actually have something called the Regional Capability Fund. We've got these new mayoral strategic authorities which are meant to play a role in public service improvement. We're giving some investment there to try and build that up. So I suppose we see growing as growing the practice of Test and Learn.

There's also another element of it which is: if we came up with a great solution – I don't know, an amazing app or something – how would we scale that? And we think that's probably more for the policy department that we're working with to scale that across the services, but that's kind of how we're thinking about it.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

Jess: So for each of our accelerators, we've got really strong links with the relevant government department as well and I think it's a really interesting but fun design feature of the programme where we're able to establish this ongoing feedback loop, between our local places who are figuring out what neighbourhood health (for example) looks like to them, but also being able to channel that back to the department so they can think about how you can use that learning at scale as well. So that's the policy element and angle to it, but we are also very much learning as we go and deepening things as well.

Nigel: The question about MoJ: so we are working potentially on an offer for all departments which is around how to do this, but then we are trying to do deeper work with some of the bigger policy departments by trying to build capabilities. That's probably most developed with the Department for Education because that's where we've done most work, but we really do want to get into that space of how can those departments design the systems and capabilities to support this way of working.

Jess: Just to slightly build on that point as well, we are looking to try to establish sister teams in other government departments as well, so we can have these parallel teams working on test, learn and grow. DfE is the front runner on that – I think we'll have a sister team which is really exciting. We're also looking at the kind of capacity within the system to do that, and we're also looking at capability building. In the autumn we'll also be publishing a playbook which will speak on some of the gaps that are perhaps in the Magenta Book, making some of the Magenta Book elements a bit more practical – like what actually working in a more iterative way looks like in practice, some of the challenges that we've encountered along the way.

Which I think comes to your final point a bit as well, in that I joined the programme officially in October last year, but was working on it from the DfE side on some of the projects like demonstrators, where we designed these 12-week projects working to really drive some rapid progress. And I think over that time, our thinking about the Test and Learn methodology feels very much like learning as we're going as well, and so kind of building knowledge of what Test and Learn looks like in practice, some of the challenges that you encounter along the way.

My reflection on that is it does actually feel very different to standard policy making or standard ways of working and actually working in a way that really tries to emphasize the multi-disciplinary element does come with challenges but can be really valuable. We're kind of figuring that out a bit as we go which does feel different and also working hand in hand with place feels different. But it does make me also think that, within departments, all of the capabilities exist already and it wouldn't really take that much to reconfigure how we're all working together. So hopefully we can nudge it along.

REFLECTIONS ON THE DAY

At the very end of the day, we conducted a wrap-up exercise called 'giveaways and takeaways'. We invited everyone to 'give away' a piece of feedback on the event itself to help us in organising any future Policy Camp; and tell us something they would 'take away' with them – an insight or action.

We have reversed the order here – takeaways first – as most readers are likely to be more interested in those. A full list of all the reflections people wrote on post-it notes can be found in the annex, along with other feedback we received.

POLICY TAKEAWAYS

One takeaway which resonated with attendees was that **'policy is a verb'** – an ongoing process, not a one-off outcome.

This participatory takeaway was reflected in another theme: **working with others**, including researchers and academia, specialists, industry, local authorities, 'teams/organisations you wouldn't necessarily think of' and 'consulting people closest to the policy impact area'.

One person who filled in the feedback form post-event had a more challenging take:

> *I was quite surprised by the disconnect between some policy professionals and the people that are impacted by policy, either citizens or staff. There were mentions about working more closely alongside people impacted by policy, which at least a few times was met with intrigue and wonder.*

They wondered if Policy Camp or something similar could provide an opportunity to connect policy and practice.

Related reflections included the value of shared learning and how community is a great way to share ideas; the need to overcome barriers to stakeholder involvement; foster co-creation; 'how to incorporate project management and policy into service delivery'; and 'wisdom on how to explore the 'next frontier' of user research – systemic and policy challenges – rather than (only) service challenges'. One 'service person' wrote that their takeaway was that 'Policy people are not aliens'.

Several people said their takeaway was to follow up with people they'd met at Policy Camp, and they welcomed the networking, relationship building and new connections.

The importance of **devolution and local government** was another theme. Specific takeaways included recognising the importance of local government; that to make devolution work, we need to shift culture around risk; and that scaling good policy means 'accepting and understanding the importance (and complexity) of local and specific contributing factors'.

Others took away **different approaches and attitudes** to policy. Several attendees talked about Test, Learn and Grow, with one reflecting that the 'Energy, capabilities and skills are already there to do Test and Learn, we need a system that enables them'; others took away systems thinking and the importance of multi-disciplinary working (including the need to codify practice). Qualities and

attitudes that people took away were the need for 'humbleness', curiosity and the need to celebrate risk-taking in recruitment and performance management. Others reflected that culture was central to delivering good outcomes, and that change can be effective if it's incremental, not just all at once.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

There were lots of other **specific takeaways** too, including:

- Reporting back to their team about the day
- Speaking to their public health team about folding harms arising from AI into their public health strategy
- Exploring issues around AI
- Using data to unlock and solve problems
- Reading the TPXimpact playbook on shaping public service markets
- Doing an internal 'sludge audit' (of the bureaucratic barriers slowing things down)
- Veering their career closer to policy-making
- Reflecting on similarities between policy-making and higher education
- Supporting the need to abolish Aim to Remit (Gambling Act)
- Taking away 'A better understanding of the policy landscape – so many passionate people working on the same topics'.

Other reflections from the 'refreshing and hopeful conversations' included:

- 'Lots of people wanting the same thing', how can we move it to action and bring in those who aren't involved in the conversation?
- 'Everyone wants to learn from each other but they also need the courage to just take the lead and try!'
- 'We do have the power to influence how policy is made'
- 'Policy is an exciting career path!'

One final takeaway for many was the **unconference format**, with several attendees wanting to run their own.

One attendee, Noel Hatch, blogged about the day: [Policy Camp: designing the conditions for collective creativity](#).



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

ORGANISER GIVEAWAYS

People left lots of **positive feedback** about Policy Camp, and wanted us to run it again. People enjoyed the format ('surprisingly good format!', 'loved freedom to organise own open discussions'), the crowdsourcing of the agenda, and the 'fascinating conversations' that ensued. 'It seems like everyone was able to experience it in the way that suited them with no pressure from organisers; in fact, you encouraged it.'

People had good things to say about the venue and location (and food), the volunteers, the 'great mix', 'great blend', 'calibre' and 'very good interdisciplinarity' of people – 'really felt like all the right people were here and with a great atmosphere!' – and the resulting 'array of perspectives' and 'diversity of thought'. People found the day useful, enjoying hearing practical insights, new ideas and new problems, and from 'well-chosen' keynotes. Those with accessibility needs felt well catered for. People used words including 'interesting', 'informative', 'valuable', 'insightful', 'intriguing', 'collaborative' and a 'very sparkly day'.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

There were differing views on what could be improved about different aspects of the day. While people fundamentally enjoyed the **format**, some people suggested having fewer, longer unconference sessions so there was longer for discussion, or some other options for longer slots with more discussion; others wanted fewer keynotes to fit in a fifth session slot ('more unconferencing'); others wanted keynotes to represent different players in the policy ecosystem, or be more of a discussion (which would also model good facilitation practice for

the unconference sessions). People also suggested running Policy Camp over two days; running smaller versions more frequently; running 'some sort of policy speed dating or more opportunities for networking'; or allowing 'different, more visual formats'.

There were suggestions on how to run the session **pitching** (or setting the agenda) differently – perhaps using a digital tool, like Slido or Menti, or running it in advance. Several people did not like the space provided for the pitching boards ('quite crowded/chaotic') and dot-voting ('a bit stressful'). Others wanted a brief description of every session to help them choose what to go to. Another was disappointed that some popular pitches did not appear to make it through to the final agenda; another that for one timeslot, there weren't enough sessions about policymaking in general which meant that none of the topics appealed to them. There was also a suggestion to keep some afternoon slots empty, so sessions could be added throughout the day to continue conversations that emerged during the morning.

As for the **sessions** themselves: consistent themes were the varying quality of the facilitation and a lack of variety in format (which were either a whole-group discussion, or small group discussions followed by group feedback). On the former, people noted that sessions were better run if someone who had pitched the idea led it, although where some session ideas had been merged, this sometimes meant the leader prioritised their pitch over the other ones merged with it. Some suggested we could offer training for convenors. On the latter, people suggested either having a default session format with guidance, or suggesting a few different formats. Some sessions were too large; some too small. Others lamented that some sessions were missing a note-taker and suggested we do more to encourage people to add to the open notes documents.

There was also feedback that the sessions were **interesting but not focused on action**. One giveaway wondered if there was a more practical opportunity to connect policy and practice in a similar format to Policy Camp, bringing together lived experience, frontline teams and policy professionals. Other comments were:

- 'Interesting discussions but not sure I saw much output'
- 'Sometimes the unfacilitated conversations feel a little aimless. With so many great minds in the room, it feels like more tangible things could be possible e.g. if it was a one-day sprint to change ways of working around a topic for example, rather than lots of separate discussions'
- 'the sessions were a little bit too strategic (blue-sky) in their topics, and...some of the challenges posed were not likely to be solved in the time allocated or necessarily by the people in the room... Of course, you can only host the sessions people put forward, but I think in future it would be great to focus minds on more practical problems and solutions that genuine policy-makers might like to hear about/offer up solutions'.

Other feedback centred on the need for **better wayfinding** and directions, and more signs ('Although I enjoyed getting lost with interesting people'), with session titles updated online more consistently and put on doors, and a clearer map; **better audiovisual facilities**, including microphones; **more seating**; more **air-conditioning**; greater representation of **frontline delivery professionals**; and **more cross-government discussion**, asking 'how is policy making different outside central government? How is it the same?' Someone also suggested enabling **non face-to-face participation**. There was also some **feedback from volunteers** on getting further briefing and not being allocated to two non-session tasks in a row so they could hear more discussion.

We will respond to suggestions in each of these areas as part of our preparation for Policy Camp 2027.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Given the success of Policy Camp 2026 (and many attendees hoping it would be the first of many), we will be thinking about an event in 2027. We will also properly digest and respond to the feedback offered, via the 'giveaways' at the end of the day, feedback form and other routes, on how to make it even better.

We're also hoping to write something about how we organised the event, to help others who have been inspired to run their own unconference.

If you would like to stay updated about future events, you should sign up for the Policy Camp newsletter on policycamp.org.uk.

We would also encourage anyone who attended Policy Camp, or is interested in the themes it raised, to check out similar events and communities and other resources. These include the following (those organised by sponsors/partners of Policy Camp are highlighted in **bold**):

- Various other government-related unconferences, including **UKGovCamp**, GovCamp Scotland, GovCamp Cymru, LocalGovCamp, Open Data Camp
- **TransformGov Talks**, a monthly in-person and virtual meetup (and where the idea for Policy Camp emerged!)
- The UK Government's Policy Design Community
- OneTeamGov
- The Communities of Practice convened by UPEN (Universities Policy Engagement Network) which aim to bring together academics and policymakers
- Apolitical's Global Policymaking Community, where folks working in policy in many different countries share resources, articles, ask questions, and more
- **Projects by IF** started a new meet up in September 2026 for those interested in the intersection of trust and technology. Sign up to their newsletter to hear more
- **TPXimpact** have launched a playbook on public-service market shaping (you can also catch up on a previous TransformGov Talks presentation where Linda and Matt talked about the work)
- **Delib** run lots of webinars. They held one earlier this year on Participation Plus+ which includes an introduction to their easy read activity type and speech to text answer components. Accessibility and hearing from voices that are often forgotten is massively important for Policy Co-design and they hope it will be of real value
- **State of the Future** runs Data Bites, a quickfire event series which highlights a range of interesting data projects (including how they can support policy). After 60 events since 2019 at the Institute for Government and then Public Digital, the series is now being run in partnership with Think Digital Partners. Gavin, director of SotF, also chairs other conferences for Think Digital Partners which are free to attend for the public sector.



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp



Source: Ned Gartside/Policy Camp

ANNEX: FULL GIVEAWAYS, TAKEAWAYS AND OTHER FEEDBACK

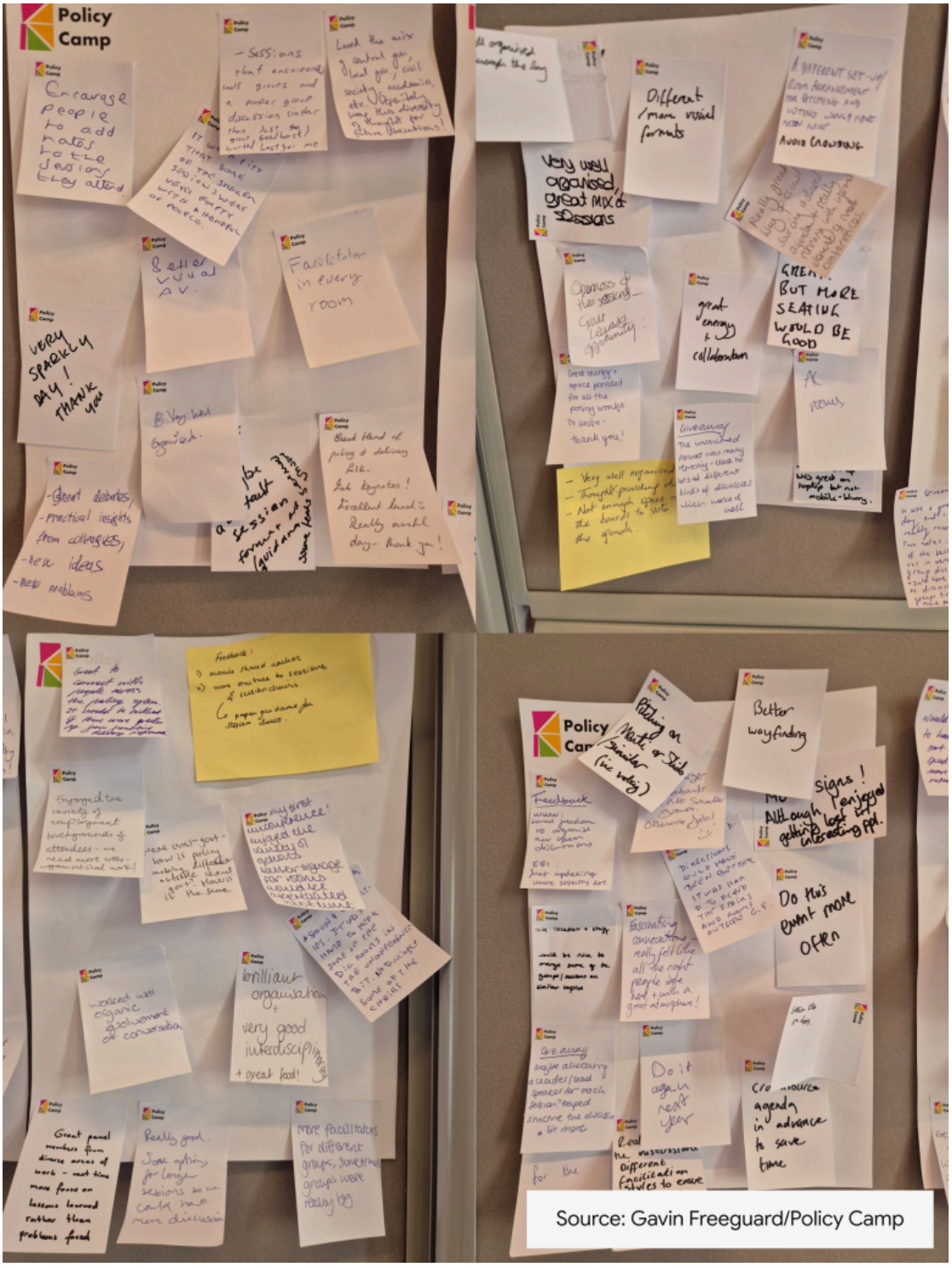
GIVEAWAYS

Board 1

- Pitching on Menti or Slido/similar (including voting)
- Better wayfinding
- What Worked Well: loved freedom to organise own open discussions; Even Better If: just updating where sessions are
- Break larger breakouts into smaller groups. Otherwise fab! :)
- More signs! Although I enjoyed getting lost with interesting people
- Directions could have been better. It was hard to find the stairs and rooms outside ground floor
- Nice location and staff. Would be nice to merge some of the groups/sessions on similar topics
- Fascinating conversations – really felt like all the right people were here and with a great atmosphere!
- Do this event more often
- Session titles on doors
- Maybe allocating a leader/lead speaker for each section? Helped structure the discussion a bit more
- Do it again next year
- Crowdsource agenda in advance to save time
- Consider Slido for the session voting?
- Really enjoyed the discussions. Different facilitation styles to ensure engagement would be helpful

Board 2

- Would be good to have some sort of policy speed dating or more opportunities for networking
- Open discussion between central and local government experiences
- Surprisingly good format! Great. Live agenda sharing was ace. Could do with maybe 1 less session so more talking time.
- When outlining/suggesting topics, there should be a brief description about what it means and what they are looking to discuss to help with choosing sessions!
- Microphones in sessions so everyone can hear
- Really enjoyed – very interactive, great mix of people



- Great that sessions are voted on! But would be good if for scheduling there are always a few general sessions, as found session 3 theme wasn't anything relevant to me!
- Exciting, great opportunity to speak without hierarchy about a range of topics from a range of voices. Ensure minute takers are in all
- It was great to hear from such an array of perspectives. I'd love to come again
- Have more signage for breakout rooms

Board 3

- Encourage people to add notes to the sessions they attend
- Sessions that incorporated small groups and a proper group discussion (rather than just group feedback) worked best for me
- Loved the mix of central government, civil society, academia, etc. Definitely keep this diversity of thought for future iterations!
- It was a pity that some of the smaller sessions were very empty with a handful of people
- Better visual a/v
- Facilitator in every room
- Very sparkly day! Thank you
- Very well organised
- Great debates – practical insights from colleagues – new ideas – new problems
- Maybe a default session format and guidance, as some session leads seemed unsure
- Great blend of policy and delivery folk. Fab keynotes! Excellent lunch :) Really useful day – thank you!

Board 4

- Great to connect with people across the policy system. It would be brilliant if there were greater representation from frontline delivery professionals
- Feedback: 1) details shared earlier, 2) more structure to sessions and session chairs -> proper guidance for session chairs
- Enjoyed the variety of employment backgrounds of attendees – we need more cross-organisational work!
- More cross-government – how is policy making different outside central government? How is it the same?
- My first unconference! Enjoyed the variety of options. Better signage for rooms would be appreciated next time.
- Sound difficulties. It was hard to hear some of the big rooms in the unconference bit. [something] some of the chairs
- Worked well. Organic evolvement of conversation
- Brilliant organisation + very good interdisciplinarity + great food!
- Great panel members from diverse areas of work – next time more focus on lessons learned rather than problems faced
- Really good. Some options for longer sessions so we could have more discussion
- More facilitators for different groups, sometimes groups were really big

Board 5

- Well organised through the day
- Different/more visual formats
- Different set-up/room arrangement for pitching and voting would have been nice. Avoid crowding.
- Very well organised, great mix of sessions
- Really great way of crowdsourcing a shared agenda + really running with informal element of most conferences
- Openness of the sessions – great learning opportunity
- Great energy and collaboration
- It was great. But more seating would be good
- Great energy + space provided for all the policy wonks to unite – thank you!
- AC rooms
- The unstructured format was really refreshing – lead to lots of different kinds of discussions which worked well
- Positive: really good to get policy together. Please do it again. Negative: the map was great on laptop but not mobile – blurry.
- Very well organised – Thought-provoking discussions – Not enough space around the boards to vote for the agenda

Board 6

- Loved it! Really easy networking
- It's been a very though-provoking and innovative unconference. I learnt the real value of policy-making. It's well-organised. I would attend the next one.
- Less oblong auditorium
- Some popular bids didn't make it through to the agenda... which I was surprised by and disappointed
- Size of group was at times a barrier – not everyone could contribute
- Overall very enjoyable first unconference! Most sessions were one large group discussion – facilitators need more encouragement to vary format!
- Enjoyed a variety of backgrounds and expertise. Helped me understand and empathise with policy professionals more.
- Opportunity to add extra planned sessions in afternoon to follow up on convos
- Even Better If: Help guides to different rooms, locating some were tricky
- 5 slots rather than 2 keynotes – more unconferencing
- It was a great day and I would really recommend. Two notes: all of the sessions I was in were full group discussions. It would have been nice to discuss in small groups first to give more people a chance to input. Second: the sessions were supposed to be a blend of multiple post-it notes (I think) but the person leading the session would only focus on their suggestion

- Very informative sessions with highly competent and knowledgeable participants across a range of organisations

Board 7

- I love how organic the day is but wonder if the sessions could benefit from more structure/common understanding
- Fantastic session – met lots of interesting people and loved the unconference format
- Voting was quite crowded/chaotic
- Really BRILLIANT idea and day. Having slightly more info on the sessions (1 line) would be helpful next time
- Welcoming, inclusive, great food, excellent well-facilitated conversation
- Networking
- Training for convenors
- Two day camp! <3 today's session
- Pitches and dot voting was chaos
- Keynote sessions were very well chosen
- Would be nice to receive a list of the people attending
- For volunteers not to be placed on 2 non-talk tasks, so 1 talk and 1 non-talk eg cloakroom as I missed a lot!
- Loved the format!
- Well-organised event that sparked conversations

Board 8

- Smaller events more frequently, sessions were too brief in some cases
- Learn and grow how we manage and brief volunteers a bit better
- I found agenda co-designing very inclusive – well done!
- Very well organised, insightful and great connections made
- Ask people to submit their pitch ideas on a platform like mimeo[?] + everyone can vote on there too! Easier to see ideas when voting if they're digital
- More structured facilitation in bigger rooms? Encourage a modified 1-2-4 (2-4-8?) to ensure everyone gets to speak?
- Structure and content of the day
- Dot voting was a bit stressful
- Great to connect with like-minded folk across different sectors
- Really good discussions, particularly enjoyed how flexible/flowing things were
- Conversations went better when the pitcher was present. 2 out of 4 for me – 50% :(
- Some light-touch facilitation support could have helped get even more from the sessions
- This was a fantastic event! It would benefit a lot of people if it could be organised again soon here at UCL [this one had dropped on the floor, not sure which board it had been stuck onto]

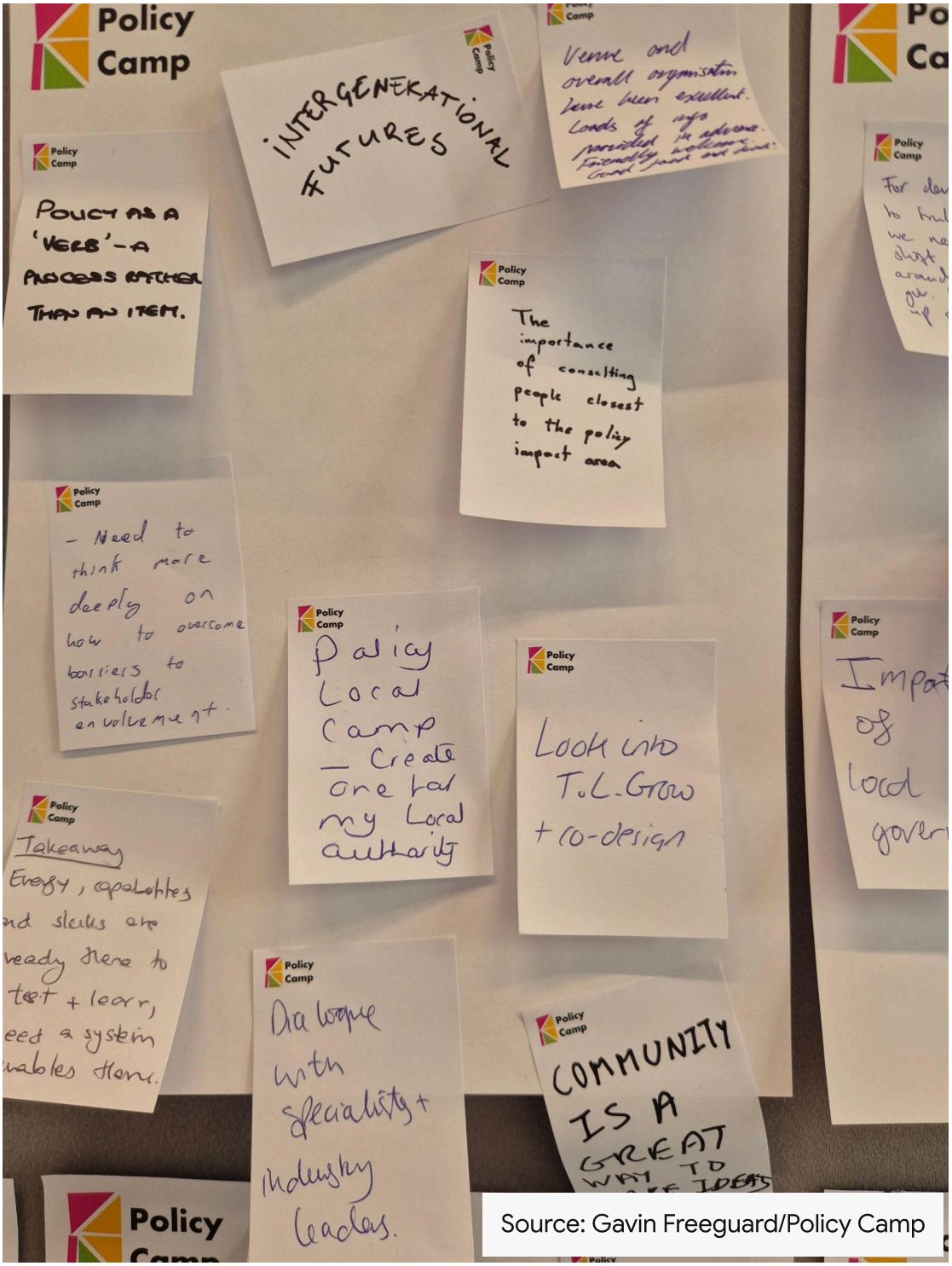
TAKEAWAYS

Board 1

- Inspired to make great policy! 😊
- How researchers can work with policy makers
- That we need to think about the contributing success factors of policies
- Read up on devolution and similar topics
- Report back to my team
- The set up on an 'unconference'
- Closer links with TLG and capability building
- Test, learn and grow – potential
- Space for connection
- Je me vouderais moins bête. Build humbleness into policy culture
- Abolish Aim to Permit! (Gambling Act)

Board 2

- Policy as a 'verb' – a process rather than an item
- Intergenerational futures
- Venue and overall organisation have been excellent. Loads of info provided in advance. Friendly welcome. Good food and drink!
- The importance of consulting people closest to the policy impact area
- Need to think more deeply on how to overcome barriers to stakeholder involvement
- Policy Local Camp – create one for my local authority
- Look into Test Learn and Grow and co-design
- Energy, capabilities and skills are already there to do test and learn, we need a system that enables them
- Dialogue with specialists and industry leaders
- Community is a great way to share ideas



Source: Gavin Freeguard/Policy Camp

Board 3

- For devolution to truly work, we need to shift the culture around risk. Central government has to give up some control
- Talk to our public health team about folding in harms of AI to public health strategy
- Multi-disciplinary is the dream! :) Can we all test, learn and grow?
- Different areas to explore in policy development
- I have never been in an unconference and was a very good experience
- Some issues to explore in AI with colleagues
- Importance of local government
- Made me think about policy as a process rather than an outcome
- The value of being able to traverse different subjects with different people

Board 4

- Data can unlock and solve problems
- Catch up with folks I've met
- Community mission challenges and test, learn and grow
- Options to potentially veer my career more into policy making
- Learned so much about policy-making and reflected on similarities in the HE sector
- Culture is central to delivering good policy outcomes – in central and local government
- Shared/sharing learning from different departments/sectors is so valuable!
- Format has inspired a new way to run other sessions
- Everyone wants to learn from each other but they also need the courage to just take the lead and try!
- [something and something] with central government "allies"

Board 5

- Do this again! Policy Camp 2027
- Speaking to local authorities directly and hearing about their experience of place-based policy
- Research more into the Test, Learn and Grow projects and be confident in talking to new people
- Fostering co-creation in policy-making
- Investing in systems change thinking is worth it
- The networking opportunity to connect with individuals – broad array of experience
- Relationships and linking up
- Curiosity
- Change can be just as effective if it's incremental vs all at once
- Don't be scared of networking!
- We do have the power to influence how policy is made

Board 6

- Really enjoyed there being multiple breakout rooms with lots of different topics
- Policy is an exciting career path!
- Various ideas on policy-making
- Scaling good policy = accepting and understanding the importance (and complexity) of local and specific contributing factors
- Check out TPXimpact market-shaping playbook for policy-makers
- Speaking to teams/organisations you wouldn't necessarily think of can be helpful
- Wisdom on how to explore the 'next frontier' of user research – systemic and policy challenges – rather than (only) service challenges
- Lots of great ideas

Board 7

- Confidence gained in the work I do
- Connections made
- Lots of different viewpoints from different organisations and sectors – really insightful!
- Consider how to incorporate project management and policy into service delivery
- Desire for more codified multi-disciplinary practice
- Spread out the pitch boards or stagger the time to put things on the boards. It was very stressful.
- Thought-provoking topics/conversations
- Do an internal 'sludge audit' perhaps? Learn more about systems thinking too :)

Board 8

- Make contact with 2 colleagues I networked with to explore mutual opportunities[?] for working together
- A better understanding of the policy landscape – so many passionate people working on the same topics
- Hearing more about what life inside the civil service is like!
- Networking
- Lots of people wanting the same thing – and how move it action and get[?] those who aren't involved in the conversation
- Unconference a brilliant way to try new topics and should be done more
- More academic involvement in policy making needed[?]
- Policy people are not aliens (from a service person)
- Great Policy Camp, really enjoyed thought-provoking topics
- In government, celebrate risk-taking and failure in recruitment and performance management. Risk-aversion happens because people worry about their careers

FEEDBACK FORM

13 people filled out the feedback form.

Scores

We asked people to score how much they enjoyed Policy Camp, and how useful it was for their work (scores 1 to 10, with 1 lowest and 10 highest).

- How much people enjoyed Policy Camp: 10/10 (7 respondents), 8/10 (5 respondents), 7/10 (1 respondent)
- How useful Policy Camp was for their work: 10/10 (6 respondents), 8/10 (3 respondents), 7/10 (1 respondent), 6/10 (2 respondents), 4/10 (1 respondent).

How would you describe your Policy Camp experience in one sentence? What did you get from it?

- Good opportunity to think outside the box.
- Very interesting and informative
- Valuable and insightful, and encouraging of cross-collaboration across stakeholder groups.
- I found it galvanising and hopeful
- Energised
- It was informative, thought-provoking, insightful, and fun!
- Policy Camp was very insightful and collaborative, a great mix of professionals from different areas and different perspectives
- Refreshing and hopeful conversations
- It was an intriguing experience where I was able to learn a lot about policy.
- A chance to connect and collaborate with diverse people working on shared policy making challenges
- It was a fun and engaging day that brought something fresh to the way we work with policy and the people that are involved with it as well as some new ideas for the unconference format.
- Interesting discussions but not sure I saw much output.
- Opportunity for collective thought

What worked well: What did you enjoy about Policy Camp? What worked well? What should we continue to do in future?

- Timings, planning, organisation
- the different discussions that you I could pick from
- I liked the unconference format, it worked quite well! I think the audience was great, there was good representation across different tiers of government, business, charities, etc. The location was superb. I also really enjoyed the key note at the start.

- I loved the free flow and reliance on the energy of the room brought by the alchemy of those who were there, it felt very didactic and real
- The 'unconferenced' nature of being able to recommend and choose topics for discussion and the openness of everyone.
- The approach to co-creating unconference agenda!
- The facilitation of the groups and the way in which topics for discussion were chosen
- Unconference format to bring discussions made networking and speaking out very easy
- What worked well was the calibre of people in attendance - it can make or break an event. I liked the fact that I was able to make it my own. I asked people their thoughts on public trust and confirmed that there is a gap between policy intent and policy experience. In future, I think you should keep the structure as is. It seems like everyone was able to experience it in the way that suited them with no pressure from organisers; in fact, you encouraged it.
- The layout was pretty good with everything off of a central area that was more than just a corridor.
- Very well organised, great venue, I really liked how the agenda was created on the day, lots of opportunity for chatting with people.
- The unconference format and scheduling of sessions worked well. It was good to have opportunities for discussion plus some keynote speeches.

What could have worked better: Is there anything you didn't enjoy about Policy Camp? Is there anything we could have done better?

- Guest speakers too many for too long
- As we were sitting in the back we couldn't see the speaker, maybe put them on a big screen so everyone can see them
- More of a practical issue, but the space in the back of the auditorium (where the introduction and keynote were hosted) wasn't a good space for the pitch selection exercise. I can see why it was selected in theory, but it was difficult to pick all pitches as you couldn't move around easily, and I had to weave my way through the crowd to get my pitch onto the board. I also think there could be more guidance on the different session structures that facilitators could use for their sessions, as a lot of sessions ended up being a large roundtable discussion. This works well, but a few other suggestions from the organisers would have been helpful (e.g. group work/ discussion, lightning round presentations to share thoughts on the core topic that was pitched).
- Super hot in the main hall room , maybe a few more fans
- The process for choosing topics could have been similar and may have benefits from a better flow or a technical solution. Some of the breakout rooms were probably a bit too big and so needed either more effective chairing in dividing up or some way to hold separate sessions.
- Include a diverse range of keynote speakers representing all key actors in policymaking, including central and local government, academia, industry, and community and third-sector organisations.
- no - it was great!

- Voting process was a bit hectic and squished. Perhaps placing boards around the room more so people can spread out.
- Yes, I think this could have easily been a 2-day event.
- Most if not all sessions I went to ended up being discussions. Supporting topic hosts with facilitating/choosing different formats might be interesting.
- I really wanted one of those purple tote bags! haha!
- Because the sessions were hosted by the person that suggested the topic, the quality of facilitation and discussion varied.
- Lunch felt a bit too long - but a minor thing really!

What we could do in future: What should we do differently, or in addition, if we run Policy Camp again?

- Enable non face to face participation
- Just re invite me, do smaller of these more regularly even. Excellent and really got me thinking.
- Would certainly recommend running Policy Camp again, it's a great opportunity to take some time to think, learn, grow and meet people. You could perhaps propose the themes earlier, this might help idea generation and more clarity on the topics. As mentioned would find a way to keep sessions to manageable numbers.
- Increased awareness for greater participation.
- Sometimes the unfacilitated conversations feel a little aimless. With so many great minds in the room, it feels like more tangible things could be possible e.g. if it was a one-day sprint to change ways of working around a topic for example, rather than lots of separate discussions.
- In future, if you intend to keep it small with only a couple of hundred people, perhaps it can be over multiple days. It was such a great event I'd attend both days. Also, a multi-day event with several hundred people could also work. We can do the pitches online in the days leading up to the event, with delegates pitching on Teams. So on the day of the event, we have some breakouts already planned, and if a few more are needed, there can be some in-person pitching.
- Keep on truckin'... Maybe make the keynotes more of an audience Q&A/panel like they would be if they were a session. That would make them more engaging and also demonstrate a possible session format for those who haven't attended before.
- I would have liked to seen more practical changes being discussed. Most conversations felt quite ideological (which is always nice to have those conversations) but perhaps lacked the specific actions to see meaningful changes
- It would be good to provide more guidance to those proposing topics or hoping to facilitate sessions e.g. on how to steer conversation and draw out points. Sessions at times felt like talking shops - all saying the same thing but not sharing best practice or ideas for change that can translate into post-event actions.

Accessibility feedback

- Well Organised I had an assigned seat and a buddy had discussed my needs
- Thank you for sorting the private room for milk expression. Hopefully you can maintain that as a standard for future sessions - it could be made more accessible if the room had a sink for washing.
- I didn't have any accessibility needs. The Gluten Free lunch was good tho'.

Keeping the conversation going: Do you think there would be any value in keeping the conversation going between Policy Camp events? What could we do? What would you find helpful?

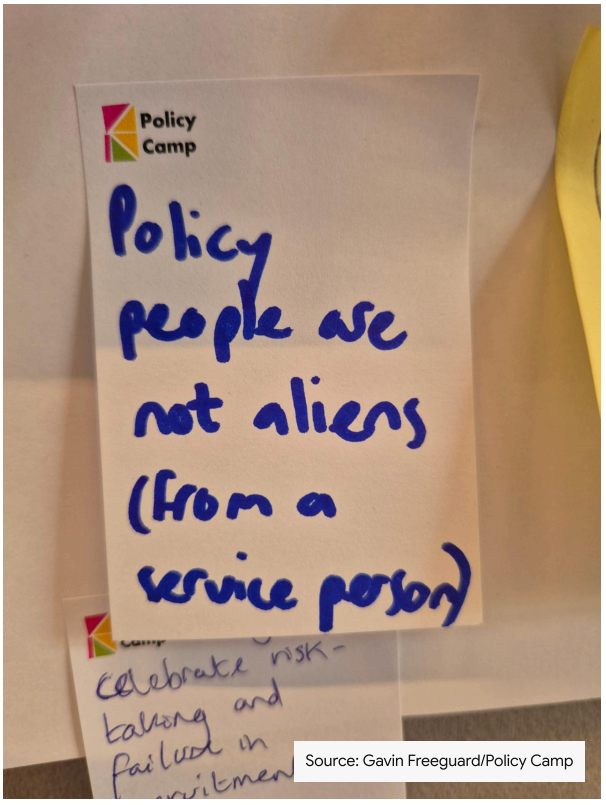
- Not sure yet. Probably a good idea.
- Yes absolutely - a newsletter, or a quarterly webinar/call would be amazing.
- 100%. I think the power is in the physical, so smaller bitesize sessions maybe topical to current events. If there is a policy announcement that is major, maybe hosting a post policy breakout room of 30 or so people etc
- A newsletter process, maybe some kind of Teams channel or ability to contact other participants to continue the discussion.
- You could share a blog post on key learnings from different Policy Camp events
- Some of the key subjects such as effective policy making from central gov to local gov could be continued to share knowledge and best practice or create forums to link up
- Optional follow up conversations around each topic - has anything changed for you in that area? Answering remaining questions etc.
- Maybe a post-event 6 months after, where delegates can meet up for drinks, reflections, and to share how they've implemented lessons learned from the camp. That would be nice.
- It sounds like a good idea but I think *Camps in general have not succeeded in communicating the vision of what this means and what the opportunities are. The community as a whole can meet once a year at the camp (or at some bar nights or something). Contacts I've made I can follow up with individually. Is there value between those extremes? Does it make sense to "recommend" events such as Data Bites? Or are we just expected to organise it ourselves in some kind of forum?
- Is it worth linking in with the Consultation Institute? They run weekly coffee mornings which are great, would be good to boost them. It would be helpful to build a wider network - not sure how best to achieve this though.

Other feedback: Is there anything else you'd like to share with us?

- Thanks for all the work that went into it.
- Just a huge well done to the team, probably the best (un)conference I've been to
- Thank you again for such a great experience. I really enjoyed it, and everyone else who was there shares the same view. It was great.
- Thank you for organising and inviting me along.

- Great work! I really enjoyed it. Thank you!
- Firstly, thanks for a great event. Overall I thought it was well organised, very interesting, and a good opportunity to hear from policy makers across government levels. This comment is more about the discussions than the event organisation - my role is not based in policy writing, I work more closely with frontline staff that are impacted by policy. I was quite surprised by the disconnect between some policy professionals and the people that are impacted by policy, either citizens or staff. There were mentions about working more closely alongside people impacted by policy, which at least a few times was met with intrigue and wonder. It might not be the goal of Policy Camp, but I think there is an opportunity to connect policy and practice in a similar format. Bringing together lived experience, frontline teams, and the cohort of policy professionals that were at Policy Camp. Otherwise, great event and thank you for putting it on. I'd definitely be interested in attending again.

Received via email



Source: Gavin Freeguard/Policy Camp

I enjoyed the day and felt you did a good job, as always though, it's easy to focus on the negatives rather than the positives so just making you aware that I think the whole thing worked mostly very well and seemed to run smoothly, so well done.

The only feedback I have is that I felt the sessions were a little bit too strategic (blue-sky) in their topics, and that some of the challenges posed were not likely to be solved in the time allocated or necessarily by the people in the room. I had initially signed up on the impression that the topics might be a bit more granular/niche and day-to-date such as high-street crime, decarbonisation of the car industry, etc. rather than big broad churches like cross-government working and is evaluation killing policy making. Of course, you can only host the sessions people put forward, but I think in future it would be great to focus minds on more practical problems and solutions that genuine policy-makers might like to hear about/offer up solutions.

Echoing this, the sessions were a bit too big with too many attendees, and I would have preferred less sessions but with more time to allocate to them.

But again, it was a really interesting day, with a great audience, interesting topics and great facilities so thank you for putting on the first of what I suspect will be many, successful camps.

THANKS

The day simply could not have happened without the support of our partners and sponsors:

- HOST AND PLATINUM SPONSOR: University College London
- PLATINUM SPONSORS: Projects by IF + Register Dynamics + Transform + TPXimpact
- GOLD SPONSORS: Design Council + Oxford Insights
- SILVER SPONSORS: Delib + UKGovCamp + Unboxed
- ORGANISING PARTNERS: Ceva + Holistic Agility + State of the Future + TPXimpact + TransformGov Talks
- MEDIA PARTNER: Civil Service World

Thank you to our excellent speakers: Jonathan Slater and Suzannah Brecknell for the morning Q&A, and Jess Hunt and Nigel Keohane for the afternoon presentation on Test, Learn and Grow.

Thank you to other unconferences for their inspiration and support – we borrowed liberally and learnt from their approaches. Thanks in particular to the organisers of UKGovCamp, GovCamp Cymru, Open Data Camp and the Connected by Data unconference.

Thanks to Ned Gartside, our excellent photographer for the day, who also pulled together the excellent compilation video on our website.

And of course a huge thank you to everyone who turned up, pitched sessions, spoke, listened, contributed and made the first Policy Camp a resounding success – hopefully the first of many.

Particular thanks are due to the organisers and volunteers who made everything run so smoothly. They are:

ORGANISERS

Alex Ash	Holly Simpson	Matt Wood-Hill
Andy Knight	Jeffrey Allen	Mike Rose
Anne Thurston	Jennifer Reed	Sally Halls
Becky Miller	Kate Haseler-Young	Sanjan Sabherwal
David Durant	Katy Beale	Stuart Turner
Gavin Freeguard	Linda O'Halloran	Vijay Luthra
Helen Brooks	Matt Thompson	Vimbai Dzimwasha

Thanks too to Alasdair de Costa, Alex Mathers, Ellie Munari, Kate Langham, Prateek Buch, and Rebecca Lester for their support earlier in the development of Policy Camp.

VOLUNTEERS

(Please get in touch if we've inadvertently missed you off!)

Adam Watkin
Dr Adrienn Tomor
Alaric Snell-Pym
Aleyna Prokudina
Alice Nolan
Amelie Thompson
Anca Tacu
Andy Bennett
Anna Lorentzon
Ashish Ramuni
Ayaan Ahmed
Ben Moore
Bilal Malik
Carl Neenan
Caroline Bond
Chelsea Dickson
Christopher Rosselot
D'jaleh McCrystal
Dave Williams
Eleanor Rogers
Eli Morley
Elizabeth Hudson
Ellie Skinner
Elze Porte
Farah Arikat
Gordon Guthrie
Habiba Muhibun Nessa
Hannah Williams
Ian Salisbury
Jean Pym
Jesse Samasuwo
Kate Spalding
Kate Wallis
Latoya Richardson
Libby Barr
Lizzie Hudson
Mairèad Rooney
Malebogo Koakae
Marianne Chiu-Lezeau
Marisha Shukla
Megha Wadhawan
Miriam Nweze
MJ Faucher-Folie
Mun Wu
Ned Gartside
Neil Fazakerley
Nina Birchard
Noel Hatch
Ododo Ediagbonya
Oliver Bulman
Poppy Llewellyn-Springett
Priya Thethi
Remy Twiringiyimana
Rob Bowman
Rose Whiffen
Sebastian Wright
Shade Abdul
Sophie Metcalfe
Zoë Wilkins

State of the Future (SotF) is a new think tank for public servants and others who believe data, digital, openness and innovation can deliver better policy, better services and better outcomes for people.

Policy Camp 2026: A summary does exactly what the title suggests. It provides a record of the first-ever Policy Camp, an unconference about improving policymaking, where those who turned up decided what was discussed.

It includes transcripts of a morning keynote session and afternoon presentation, notes from the unconference sessions, and what attendees took away from the day (as well as feedback for organisers).

State of the Future is one of the organising partners of Policy Camp. You can find out more about Policy Camp at **policycamp.org.uk**

October 2026

sotf.org.uk | gavin@sotf.org.uk

State of the Future is currently a project of Gavin Freeguard Ltd (company number 13214981)

STATE OF THE FUTURE